

# Seven Seeds for Flourishing

By

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# Foreword

by Billy Humphrey

I've had the privilege of walking alongside Hazen Stevens in life and ministry for 20 years. Hazen has been a dear friend, a co-laborer, and a brother in the gospel. I've come to know him as a man of deep passion, unwavering faith, and a rare sincerity that marks those who truly know the Lord. From countless hours in the place of prayer to leading movements that call people into unity and wholehearted devotion, his life is a testimony of what it means to be deeply rooted in the love of God and moving in His power.

The book you hold in your hands is an invitation and a guide. Hazen has taken profound spiritual truths and made them accessible to us all. Using the imagery of a garden, he invites us into a growing and vibrant spirituality—one that is available to anyone, regardless of where they live, work, or find themselves on their journey. He draws from his own experiences in life, mission, and ministry to illustrate how the “Seven Seeds” can be cultivated in anyone's life. Hazen sees what many of us often miss: the life of faith isn't a moment but a process, one that requires careful tending, patient cultivation, and a deep dependence on the wisdom of Jesus, our Master Gardener.

This book carries within it the promise of transformation—principles that, when planted in the soil of your heart, will lead you into a truly Spirit-empowered life. As you engage with these truths, you'll find yourself being formed and strengthened in a way that mirrors the faith of the apostles.

Hazen writes with evident wisdom and clarity because he isn't offering theory; he's inviting you into a journey he is walking himself. He is living what he teaches, and the fruit of his life and family speaks as loud as the words on these pages.

So lean in, read with an open heart, and allow these truths to take root in you. If you will, I believe you'll find yourself flourishing—not just for a season, but for a lifetime.

Billy Humphrey



# Prologue

As I write this introductory chapter, I'm sitting in the Great Rift Valley under a tin roof, with rain gently dripping above me. The sights and sounds of this place remind me of the incredible opportunities God has given me to teach and preach all over the world. recently arrived to share at the Healthy Church Conference here in Tororo, Uganda, with a short-term mission group from our home church.

We hosted a conference for pastors and leaders, breaking down the seven seeds described in this book. These leaders testified that this truth was revolutionary, giving them insight into some aspects of the early church that they had previously neglected. Before embarking on this mission trip to Uganda and Kenya, I had delivered a message titled 'A Call to Remember' at my home church in Lawrenceville, Georgia. In it, I introduced the seven seeds we will explore in this book.

That same day, we hosted a prayer meeting in the heart of Atlanta, which was a remarkable moment. My wife and I had spent 17 years in Lawrenceville before sensing God's call to return inside the perimeter, specifically to Buckhead—the affluent suburb where I grew up. During this inaugural prayer meeting preparing the way for

our coming church plant, we distributed physical keys to the people in attendance, asking them to commit to praying these seven qualities over the new baby church. As spiritual ‘gatekeepers’ equipped with keys, they were invited to embody these values within the culture of our city.

Since then, the values of this book have informed who we are as a new community. We’re in the thick of figuring out how to live this way. I’m persuaded it can’t just be about teaching the apostolic ways; we must embody these values in family and community. As we press into these values, we’re being changed.

Later that summer, when we conducted our conference on church health in Tororo, pastors and leaders also testified to being incredibly impacted. They saw aspects of the early church, which they had previously overlooked, come alive with fresh relevance. This confirmed to me that these seven seeds aren’t only important truths, but *essential* elements for a flourishing Christian life and community no matter where you may be in the world.

These points I’m highlighting are the litmus tests of profound biblical truth: (1) Is it a truth that bears fruit as we live it out? and (2) Can it be lived out by any believer in any time and in any part of the world? My recent experiences from Atlanta to Uganda are causing my heart to shout a resounding "Yes!" when I consider the 'seven seeds of flourishing.'

As you dive into this book, I expect you'll discover the same joyful truth I have. The seeds for transformation aren't complicated or mysterious; they're offensively simple and obvious. They must be remembered and, through hard work, put into practice. As you practice them, I believe a fruitful garden will soon spring forth from your life, and you'll flourish abundantly like never before.

# Chapter 1

## An Introduction to Seven Seeds

In my teenage years, I had the unique opportunity to work as an intern at the Atlanta Botanical Garden. As part of a special senior year project, I spent every week immersed in the vibrant and diverse plant life of the gardens. One of the most awe-inspiring places was the Orchid Center—a breathtaking cloud forest oasis within the greenhouses at the edge of Piedmont Park. Inside, exotic orchids bloomed in dazzling arrays of color and form, flourishing in an environment carefully curated to mimic their natural habitat.

What always struck me was how these majestic plants began from seeds so minuscule they were nearly invisible to the naked eye. We would carefully place these seeds in special nutrient-rich dishes designed to give them the head start they needed to flourish. Over the years, the image of those seeds and their transformation into thriving orchids has stayed with me as a metaphor for spiritual growth. If you want your life and community to grow into a flourishing garden, it starts with planting seeds—seeds of transformation and truth.

These are the seeds that God planted in the early church that grew into a vibrant, fruitful community. Just as those tiny seeds were placed in fertile conditions to grow into the beauty of a botanical garden, so must we cultivate the seeds of flourishing in our hearts and communities.

As we plant a church—and as you, the reader, plant the seeds in your own spiritual journey—these truths will take root and grow into transformed lives, bearing fruit 30, 60, and even a hundredfold. This is the purpose and context of this book. As you plant and nurture these principles within the context of community, your life will blossom just as those orchids did, exploding into vibrancy and life.

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## Overview of the Seven Seeds

The seven seeds outlined in Acts chapter two provide a roadmap for remembering and embracing the apostolic path. Let's read this passage together:

Acts 2:40-47 (NIV):

- Salvation: "With many other words he warned them; and he pleaded with them, 'Save yourselves from this corrupt generation.' Those who accepted his message were baptized,

and about three thousand were added to their number that day" (vv. 40-41).

- Devotion: "They devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching and to fellowship, to the breaking of bread and to prayer" (v. 42).
- Power: "Everyone was filled with awe at the many wonders and signs performed by the apostles" (v. 43).
- Unity: "All the believers were together and had everything in common" (v. 44).
- Generosity: "They sold property and possessions to give to anyone who had need. Every day they continued to meet together in the temple courts" (v. 45).
- Cultural Impact: "They broke bread in their homes and ate together with glad and sincere hearts, praising God and enjoying the favor of all the people" (v. 46).
- Growth: "And the Lord added to their number daily those who were being saved" (v. 47).

These seven seeds presented in this description of the early church—salvation, devotion, power, unity, generosity, cultural impact, and growth—are values planted in the soil of these new believers' hearts. They're practices that contain the potential for

transformation and flourishing, not only within individual believers but within entire communities of faith. Let's spell them out.

1. Seed of Salvation

Salvation through Jesus Christ is foundational. Acts 2:21 declares, "And everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved" (NIV). Salvation begins our journey with God and anchors our faith.

2. Seed of Devotion

Acts 2:42 emphasizes devotion to Scripture, fellowship, communion, and prayer. This devotion cultivates spiritual growth and creates a deep-rooted faith.

3. Seed of Power

Acts 2:43 reveals the awe-inspiring power of the Holy Spirit through wonders and signs, which transforms lives and bears witness to God's presence.

4. Seed of Unity

Unity, as seen in Acts 2:44-46, transcends cultural and economic barriers, which fosters a community reflecting God's love.

## 5. Seed of Generosity

Acts 2:45 shows believers sharing their resources. Generosity demonstrates faith in action and deep commitment to one another.

## 6. Seed of Cultural Impact

Acts 2:47 depicts a church engaging with and influencing its surrounding culture, earning favor through love and compassion even with those not yet considered part of the faith community.

## 7. Seed of Church Growth

As the church lived out these principles, Acts 2:47 records that “the Lord added to their number daily those who were being saved” (NIV). Growth is both spiritual and numerical, a result of authentic and vibrant faith.

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# The Eternal Perspective

These seeds aren’t merely historical principles embraced by the first century church; they’re a taste of the eternal Kingdom of Heaven. By cultivating them in our lives and communities, we draw heaven’s eternal values into the present, as Jesus taught us to pray, “Your



kingdom come, Your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven" (NIV, Matt. 6:10). In these values we recall the past, but also anticipate the future!

One day, in God's eternal Kingdom, we who are 'saved' through new birth in this life will be immortally glorified in our bodies (*amazing right!*), experiencing the fullness of our salvation, which is God's promise to us. "For our citizenship is in heaven, from which we also eagerly wait for the Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ, who will transform our lowly body, that it may be conformed to His glorious body" (NIV, Phil. 3:20–21).

In eternity, we'll be endlessly devoted to God, as the heavenly chorus cries out, "Holy, holy, holy, Lord God Almighty, who was and is and is to come!" (NIV, Rev. 4:8).

His power will renew creation, and the earth will be filled again with His glory as it was in Eden. His glory will fill the earth in the same way 'the waters cover the sea' (NIV, Hab. 2:14).

United as one people, we'll fulfill Jesus' prayer that we "may be one, as You, Father, are in Me, and I in You" (NIV, John 17:21).

In addition, we'll experience the generous riches of eternal reward, for Jesus promised, "Great is your reward in heaven" (NIV, Matt. 5:12).

Every part of *culture will be impacted* as His Kingdom branches out from Zion, beautiful and glorious, growing to fill the whole earth. As Isaiah prophesied, "The mountain of the Lord's house shall be established on the top of the mountains, and all nations shall flow to it" (NIV, Isa. 2:2), and "On that day the Branch of the Lord will be beautiful and glorious" (NIV, Isa. 4:2).

Additionally, we're assured that "Of the increase of His government and peace there will be no end" (NIV, Isa. 9:7), pointing to the unstoppable *growth* of Christ's Kingdom throughout all creation.

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## Conclusion: The Transformative Power of Spiritual Seeds

In my days as a volunteer at the botanical gardens, I learned about a phenomenon called the 'super bloom.' In arid regions like the California deserts, for years, seeds from wildflowers such as desert gold, lupines, and poppies lie dormant in the dry, nutrient-poor soil, appearing lifeless and forgotten. Yet, these seeds possess extraordinary resilience and potential.

When times of exceptional rainfall occur, the barren desert undergoes a breathtaking transformation. The water penetrates the dry ground, activating seeds that have been lying in wait, sometimes

for decades. Within weeks, vibrant flowers blanket the desert in a stunning display of renewal and life, showcasing the power hidden in dormancy just below the surface.

This process is a remarkable testament to the vitality of seeds. It reminds us that, even under seemingly impossible conditions, with the right timing and environment, life can flourish.

Similarly, the spiritual seeds of flourishing in our lives may seem dormant at times, waiting for the right conditions to bloom. When watered by God's Spirit in the context of community, these seeds we've described can renew our lives and transform them into a garden oasis.

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## Prayer of Blessing to Commence the Reading of Seven Seeds

The imagery of seeds planted and nurtured has been a recurring theme in my journey, from my time at the Atlanta Botanical Garden to my ministry experiences. Just as the orchids I cared for as a teenager required careful attention and the right environment to thrive, so do the seeds of transformation in our spiritual lives. Planted in good soil and cultivated with care, they can grow into vibrant, fruitful expressions of God's Kingdom.

This is my hope for you, whether you are a new believer, a seasoned believer, or a ministry leader. My desire is for you to have a vibrant spiritual life. I believe these seeds hold the potential to transform you. As you nurture these values, may they grow into a garden, bearing fruit that will last for eternity.

Join me, as I pray this prayer below over you as a reader.

Heavenly Father,

We come before You with hearts open and expectant as we begin this journey through the truths in this book, *Seven Seeds*. Thank You for the gift of remembrance and the beauty of transformation that You weave into our lives through Your Word and Spirit. As we reflect on the imagery of seeds, may we be reminded of Your faithfulness to bring life from the smallest beginnings and to cultivate flourishing even in barren places.

Lord, we ask for Your blessing over each reader. May their hearts be good soil for the seeds of truth, wisdom, and transformation found in these pages. Let Your Word take root deeply, growing into a vibrant garden that reflects Your glory.

Inspire us to recall our foundational priorities, reflect on our unique journeys, and learn from the history of Your

faithfulness. Anchor us in gratitude and fill us with awe as we celebrate Your goodness.

We ask for Your Spirit to guide us as we engage with these teachings. Help us not only to understand but to live out these principles, bringing transformation to our lives, our communities, and every sphere of society. May these seeds bear fruit that will last—30, 60, and a hundredfold—multiplying Your Kingdom purposes in the earth.

We dedicate this time of reflection and learning to You, trusting that the same God who brings beauty from ashes and gardens from deserts will do immeasurably more than we could ask or imagine. Let Your Kingdom come and Your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven.

In the name of Jesus, our Savior and the Branch of Life,

Amen.

# Chapter 2

## Remembering the Seven Seeds

### The Value of Remembering

In this recent season as I approach my 40th birthday, I've been reflecting on the importance of remembrance—specifically, considering who we're called to be as the body of Christ. Over nearly two decades in ministry, I've been privileged to witness incredible teaching on the identity of the church from Scripture.

Most of us are familiar with the concept of being children of God, the bride of Christ, or a part of the priesthood of believers. These powerful identities are often emphasized in Western contexts as individual truths. However, as we explore the seven seeds, I want to focus on how these identities also apply to our corporate calling as the church.

The story of the church is far greater than any single individual. It's a narrative stretching back to Abraham, the father of our faith, and the protoevangelium—the promise to Eve that her seed would crush the serpent's seed. This gospel promise has been carried forward by

the family of faith, culminating in the fullness of Christ's first coming and the outpouring of the Holy Spirit. We all still await together, as one family, for the fullness of the Kingdom. We are part of this unfolding story, called to live in the reality of the Kingdom of God both now and forever.

In looking at those who have traversed the roads of faith before us, the Bible frequently calls us to remember the acts of God and our identity as God's chosen people. These acts of remembrance serve as spiritual anchors, helping us align our present lives with God's eternal purposes.

## 1. Refocus on Foundational Priorities

"Remember therefore from where you have fallen; repent and do the first works" (NIV, Rev. 2:5). In this charge to the Ephesian church, Jesus emphasizes the importance of evaluating and realigning with core values. Organizations and individuals alike are challenged to revisit their foundational practices and rekindle the passion that fuels their mission, ensuring sustained growth and impact.

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## 2. Reflect on Your Unique Journey

"I am reminded of your sincere faith, which first lived in your grandmother Lois and in your mother Eunice" (NIV, 2 Tim. 1:5-7). Paul's words to Timothy can serve as a deeply personal reminder for each of us to consider the spiritual and professional influences that have shaped our journey. Just as Timothy is encouraged to fan into flame his God-given gifts, we're invited to recognize and steward our unique potential with power, love, and discipline.

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## 3. Draw Lessons from History

"Now these things occurred as examples to keep us from setting our hearts on evil things as they did" (NIV, 1 Cor. 10:1-12). Paul's recounting of Israel's wilderness journey underscores the importance of learning from the past. For teams and leaders, it's a call to examine previous challenges both personal and historical, celebrate moments of divine provision, and avoid the missteps that can derail progress toward shared goals.

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#### 4. Stay Anchored in Gratitude

"Be careful that you do not forget the Lord, who brought you out of Egypt, out of the land of slavery" (NIV, Deu. 6:12). Whether applied to an organization reflecting on milestones or to an individual recalling personal breakthroughs, Moses' command encourages a posture of gratitude. By actively remembering transformative moments, we foster humility and a renewed sense of purpose.

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#### 5. Celebrate God's Goodness in Your Life

"Praise the Lord, my soul, and forget not all his benefits" (NIV, Ps. 103:2-5). This psalm invites a personal moment of reflection on God's kindness and faithfulness. It's a reminder to celebrate the ways He forgives, heals, redeems, and renews us—personally and collectively—providing the energy and joy to face each day with hope.

Each of these passages reveals that remembering God's works and promises is far more than an intellectual exercise—it's a vital spiritual discipline. It calls us to realign our actions, renew our hope, and reaffirm our identity in Christ. Throughout this book, you'll be prompted to reflect and remember in the ways outlined above:

recalling foundational priorities, reflecting on your unique journey, learning from the past, staying anchored in gratitude, and celebrating God's goodness in your life.

By looking back on His faithfulness, you'll find strength to persevere and clarity to align your life with His eternal purposes.

Reflection—on Scripture, Christian history, and your own spiritual journey—will be a recurring theme, offering opportunities to deepen your faith and walk more fully in God's plan.

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## Returning to Apostolic Paths

Therefore, we need to remember where we've been as a people—corporately, individually, and historically. We need to be instructed by remembering the lessons of those who have gone before us. It takes time to intentionally slow down and reflect on the lessons of the past, both those which are bad and we don't want to repeat, and those which are good and need to be reclaimed. This is the *key* to most historic reformations—returning to the apostolic roots and correcting the errant departures.

In Jeremiah 6:16, during a critical moment when Jeremiah is prophesying the judgments to come from the nation of Babylon, he tells them to look for the ancient paths, to stand at the crossroads

and see the good way, so that they would find rest for their souls. Sadly, Israel did not respond to God's admonition, but rather continued in their rebellion and suffered the consequences.

Today, we have a similar invitation from both the Scriptures and the Spirit of God, inviting us to remember who we're called to be, to stand at the fork in the road, and choose the path that so many of the people of God have rightfully chosen in the past. We must reject the pathways of spiritual decline and moral disobedience. Instead, we need to embrace a lifestyle that embodies the apostolic church, ultimately bringing forth the reality of the Kingdom of God on earth as it will be one day in its fullness.

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## Presenting the Seven Seeds: The Story of Sally and Sunday

While presenting these seven seeds to our Ugandan brothers and sisters in Tororo, Uganda, I employed a tool that I had used just a few weeks earlier when sharing the same message with our spiritual family. It's a mnemonic device—a sentence used to help remember things.

The mnemonic device that I introduced was a simple one. "Sally's salvation led to devotion with power, unity, and generosity,

producing impact in her family and spiritual growth in her sisters.” In this story, we hear about Sally, who makes a commitment to Jesus and begins to live a devoted life that expresses itself through the power of the Holy Spirit. Then she experiences unity with other believers. As she lives a life of generosity both financially and in heart, she ultimately impacts her culture, creating spiritual growth and salvation in her sphere.

In this story, we learn all seven of the keys in the correct sequence. It’s an easy way to remember the seven seeds that we introduced in the previous chapter: Salvation, Devotion, Power, Unity, Generosity, Cultural Impact, and Growth. What fun it was to introduce it to our Ugandan brothers and sisters! In our Western context, people simply used the sentence to memorize the seven keys.

However, the Ugandan believers embraced the story enthusiastically, adding some creative embellishment. Instead of Sally, we used a common name there and told the story of Sister Sunday.

It was a joy to hear Ugandans telling Sister Sunday’s story. Each day, a different person would retell her tale. They elaborated on how she got saved, what her devotional life looked like, how she embraced the Spirit’s power, engaged with unity, and how generosity affected her life. Ultimately, they shared the impact she was having on others and the growth it was causing in her family and the church.

As they embraced the story with each telling, you could see lightbulbs going on. People were finding a simple path to begin embodying these qualities—simple storyline to profound clarity.

At our final service for our team, many testified that this simple retelling of the ‘seven seeds’ had caused them to consider areas where their own faith wasn’t expressing itself fully. It motivated them to reflect: “Where am I lacking in my spiritual life, and what am I going to do about it?”

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## Creating Your Own Story

Today, I want to invite you to create a story yourself about Sister Sally or Sister Sunday. Think about how she got saved in your mind. Was it a friend who shared the gospel with her? Did she answer an altar call at a church service? Imagine her first moment waking up, reading the Bible, praying, and feeling the presence of God within herself as a born-again believer.

Think about how she might have prayed and asked for the power of the Holy Spirit and the gifts of the Spirit to be expressed in her life. Imagine how she chose to join a body and began regularly attending a church in her city, knitting her heart in spiritual family to other believers. Consider how she began to give financially and to share

her life with others generously, inviting people into her home to show hospitality and care for those who were in need in her community.

Lastly, think about how her neighbors saw the transformation in her life and grew curious about her faith. What is happening in Sally or Sunday's life that's causing her to live differently, talk differently, and express her time and energy in new, more generous and loving ways? Ultimately, consider how her close family members and friends were challenged or inspired by her example.

Now in light of this scenario, consider the description of the Christian's life in 2 Corinthians 2:15-16 (NLT; emphasis mine). "Our lives are a Christ-like fragrance rising up to God. But this fragrance is perceived differently by those who are being saved and by those who are perishing. To those who are perishing, we are a dreadful smell of death and doom. But to those who are being saved, we are a life-giving perfume."

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## Reflection and Application

This exercise is designed to help you quickly internalize the seven keys and apply them in a practical way for yourself and others. The first two keys—salvation and devotion—are deeply personal

practices that take root in a person's heart. The next three—power, unity, and generosity—are primarily expressed within the context of the community of faith. Finally, the last two—cultural impact and growth—serve as outward expressions, flowing from the community into the broader world.

As you reflect on this exercise, you may find that it doesn't just apply to a fictional scenario. In addition, it resonates with your own journey, inviting you to see where these keys are already at work in your life and where they can grow further.

I imagine each of these seven characteristics of the early church have touched your own life. Remember the time when you first made a commitment to Jesus.

- What was it like in that season of 'first love' for you to feel the touch of God's presence on your soul and the joy and peace that came from the assurance of eternal salvation?
- What was it like to read the Word of God and have the Holy Spirit give you insight?
- Have you ever seen God's power expressed through your life as you spoke prophetically, gained knowledge that could only be given by the Holy Spirit, or perhaps prayed for someone who was sick or oppressed and saw them healed or delivered? Have you experienced the joy of united prayer or

the taking of communion, which shows the beauty and unity of the body as we come into oneness with Christ and each other?

- Have you experienced the joy of giving secretly in an extravagant way that answered the need of another?

Ultimately, have you seen the way that your life created an impact on others, causing them to grow spiritually? This is what the Christian life is all about. Perhaps as you're reading this, you recall a time where these different points were significant in your own life. Possibly, now it's time for one or two of them to be renewed. Maybe there's one that's completely absent.

Perhaps you grew up in an environment like I did where there was little spoken about the power of God being expressed by the Holy Spirit. In seasons past, have you had a dedicated devotional life, but it has waned over the years of your Christian walk? Now is the time for renewal in that area of your faith walk.

This book is an invitation—an invitation to experience new things as well as consider things that have been neglected in your life. Maybe it's the time to make a choice to live with all these seeds growing to full bloom, filling the Garden of your soul as a sanctuary



of fruitfulness for God to delight in. Maybe it's time for your life to give off the fragrance of life to all those around you!

Here's a closing challenge—commit these seven seeds to heart, and memorize and meditate on them in the coming weeks.

# Chapter 3

## The Necessity of Salvation

### Personal Transformation Through Commitment

My own journey to understanding salvation began in a Baptist church near the farm where I lived in Marietta, Georgia. As a child, I had gone to my mother with a question: “How do I know if God is real?” She was a baby Christian herself and unsure how to answer me as a 6 year old. So, she took me to the pastor of the little country church, Mount Calvary Baptist. I remember he was a kind man, and I felt at ease in his presence.

When my mother brought me into his office, I asked him my question. He invited me to join him behind his desk, looking out the window. With a hand on my shoulder, he pointed outside and asked me what I saw. I vividly remember the pine trees on the edge of the little asphalt parking lot, the blue sky, and birds fluttering about. As I looked out, he explained that all I saw was the work of a kind Creator who loved and made me. In that moment, I felt God’s presence and a conviction that He was real.

Yet, as I grew older and faced life's challenges—like my parents' divorce and the hypocrisy I witnessed during a church split—I distanced myself from God. By high school, I had walked away, chasing relationships, money, and popularity, all pursuits that ultimately left me empty.

A broken dating relationship in my twenties brought me to a turning point. During a church service in that difficult season, the preacher spoke about how focusing on our parents' faults can lead us to repeat their mistakes. Suddenly, I realized I was following the same patterns I had vowed to avoid. The pastor urged us to ask God for new spiritual DNA and allow Him to transform our lives.

That day, I prayed, asking God to be my Father and make me His son. While external changes took time, my heart underwent a dramatic transformation. I began addressing sinful patterns and embracing the Holy Spirit's work in my life.

Now, over 20 years removed from that season, I am married with four beautiful children. God's grace has blessed me with a loving family and a deep sense of peace and purpose. Even in hardship, I experience the confidence and joy of walking daily with God.

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## Invitation to Believe and Receive

I want to emphasize a critical truth. This message can be heard and understood, but not truly received. During my years of half-hearted church attendance, I knew theological truths but had not surrendered to them. As James 2:19 reminds us, "You believe that there is one God. You do well. Even the demons believe—and tremble!" (NIV). Knowing the truth is not enough; true transformation requires surrender and action—a faith that moves beyond intellectual agreement to wholehearted devotion.

Campus Crusade for Christ's four spiritual laws summarize salvation simply:

1. God loves you and has a plan for your life.
2. Our sin and brokenness separate us from Him.
3. Through His death and resurrection, Jesus restores us to God's plan.
4. We must believe and receive these truths personally.

The fourth step is where many falter. It's not enough to intellectually accept these truths; we must surrender to them. True faith requires opening our hearts to Jesus and allowing His power to transform us. Have you made that step of surrender?

In my twenties, I knew God's truths, but hadn't experienced their power until I surrendered. It was in that moment—believing *and* receiving—that true transformation occurred. This experience underscores my conviction that salvation is deeply spiritual and transformative. When we truly surrender, we move from knowing about God to walking in the fullness of life He offers, as we truly come to know Him.

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## The Necessity of Salvation and the Act of Baptism

As you see from my own story, salvation isn't merely an intellectual concept; it's the very foundation of our daily transformation and eternal hope. In 1 Peter 3:21, Peter explains that baptism is more than a ritual—it symbolizes the appeal of a cleansed conscience before God through the resurrection of Jesus Christ. "Baptism, which corresponds to this, now saves you, not as a removal of dirt from the body but as an appeal to God for a good conscience, through the resurrection of Jesus Christ" (NIV).

Paul expands on this in Romans 6:3-4, showing how baptism represents our identification with Christ's death and resurrection.

"Or do you not know that all of us who have been baptized into Christ Jesus were baptized into his death? We were therefore buried with him by baptism into death, in order that, just as Christ was raised from the dead by the glory of the Father, we too might walk in newness of life" (NIV).

Baptism is an emblem of our death to sin as we are joined to Christ and our resurrection into His life and power. This act symbolizes the miracle of new birth: the greatest of all miracles. As Amy Carmichael, a famous missionary to India, aptly puts it, "I could no sooner create a star than cause a soul to be born again."

This understanding of baptism is central to Peter's exhortation in Acts 2:38. After preaching to the crowd at Pentecost and convicting them of their need for salvation, Peter urged them to respond. "Peter said to them, 'Repent and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the forgiveness of your sins, and you will receive the gift of the Holy Spirit'" (NIV).

In this powerful moment, Peter tied the *physical* act of baptism to the *spiritual* realities of repentance, forgiveness, and receiving the Holy Spirit. This call to baptism echoed through the early church as a declaration of salvation and an outward sign of the inward transformation brought about by faith in Christ.

Therefore, baptism isn't merely a ritual; it's the public proclamation of our death to sin and resurrection into new life through Christ. It serves as a tangible reminder of the miraculous work of salvation, aligning us with the life, death, and resurrection of our Savior and empowering us to walk in the newness of life.

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## Reflection and Application

Let's take a moment to reflect.

- Have you truly believed and received Jesus as your Lord and Savior?
- Are you living with the assurance of salvation?
- What about those around you—do they know the transformative power of the gospel?

As Paul wrote, “Examine yourselves to see whether you are in the faith” (NIV, 2 Cor. 13:5). Have you been baptized as a public declaration of your faith?

Moreover, salvation isn't just a concept; it's the miracle of passing from death to life, from darkness to light. It transforms our hearts, renews our minds, and reshapes our lives. This foundational truth is

the seed of a transformed life, and it's too precious to keep to ourselves. As you marvel at the depth and beauty of God's saving grace, let it stir a desire to share this message with others.

Challenge those around you to move beyond intellectual assent and step into the life-changing power of faith in Jesus Christ. Let's daily feast on these truths, celebrating the miracle of new birth and embracing the privilege of making them known. Salvation isn't only necessary—it's the greatest gift we'll ever receive. May we treasure it, live it, and boldly proclaim it to a world in desperate need of hope in this life and for eternity.



# Chapter 4

## Devotion

As we move from exploring the miraculous work of salvation, we now turn to the life that unfolds after the mystery of new birth takes place. Salvation isn't the end of the journey, but the beginning of a transformational relationship with God. When I surrendered my life to Him and accepted Jesus as my Lord and Savior, everything changed. A new hunger took root in my heart—a longing for the Word of God, a desire to commune with Him in prayer, and a deep need for fellowship with other believers.

Acts 2:42 beautifully captures this devotion in the early church. "All the believers devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching, to fellowship, to sharing in meals, including the Lord's Supper, and to prayer" (NIV).

This devotion wasn't a fleeting feeling or a casual commitment. It became the foundation of their lives, shaping their hearts and communities. It serves as our model for spiritual growth today. Let's examine the key aspects of this devotion—to the Word of God, to prayer, and to fellowship—and consider how these practices can

transform our lives as they did for the early church.

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## Devotion to the Apostles' Teaching

The early church's devotion to the apostles' teaching underscores the centrality of God's Word in their lives. For us, this means immersing ourselves *daily* in Scripture—reading, studying, meditating, and applying its truths.

Jesus declared in Matthew 4:4, “Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that comes from the mouth of God” (NIV). Scripture isn't merely nourishment for the soul; it's essential for life itself.

Psalm 119:105 echoes this truth. “Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path” (NIV). Just as a flashlight pierces through utter darkness, the Word of God illuminates our way, guiding us through life's uncertainties and challenges.

Paul's words to Timothy in 2 Timothy 3:16-17 (parentheses mine) further reveal the transformative power of Scripture. “All Scripture is breathed out by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness, that the man (or woman) of God may be complete, equipped for every good work” (NIV).

We can only be complete as a man or woman of God as we receive from the Word. Scripture doesn't merely inform us; it equips and sanctifies us, transforming us into Christ's image. This truth has profoundly shaped my life.

It was so impactful in my early walk with Jesus that my wife and I chose to inscribe portions of John 17:17 inside our wedding rings. Her ring reads, "Sanctify us in truth..." (NIV), while mine completes the prayer with "...your word is truth" (NIV). These words remind us daily of Jesus' prayer for our transformation—a transformation that only occurs as the Spirit administers the truth of God's Word to our lives.

How has Scripture been a lamp to your feet and a light to your path? As you reflect, consider how immersing yourself daily in God's Word can guide, equip, and transform you in ways you never imagined.

## Personal Experience with the Word

One of the most transformational seasons in my life was when I created a reading plan that had me in multiple portions of the Bible daily. For the first time, I read through the entire Bible in about four months, covering 15 to 25 chapters each day. Simultaneously, this plan took me through Genesis to Exodus, the prophets, the Gospels, the Epistles, and Revelation.

Since I spent daily time in the beginning, middle, and end of the Bible, it gave me a new perspective on the broader narrative of Scripture. As a result, this season changed my understanding of the Bible and deepened my faith. A *daily* commitment to the Word of God can't be overstated.

In addition, the Word of God is our daily bread. Just as freshly baked bread nourishes the body, the fresh revelation of Scripture nourishes the soul, bringing strength and delight. My wife is an amazing cook, and one of her gifts is baking fresh bread for our family and guests. She grinds flour straight from the grain and bakes it with no preservatives, creating bread that's both delicious and nourishing. In our house, it's quickly consumed—and loved.

This reminds me of how the Holy Spirit prepares the Word in our hearts daily, making it fresh, nourishing, and delightful. Just as I eagerly anticipate her bread, we should daily delight in the bread of heaven that God provides through His Word. There truly is nothing more satisfying than fresh bread—whether physical or spiritual. Just as bread strengthens our bodies, the Word strengthens our souls, giving us what we need to thrive in life and faith.

## Practical Steps for Engaging with Scripture

- Daily Reading

Begin a consistent rhythm of engaging with Scripture. Follow a reading plan that takes you through diverse portions of the Bible. Consider using a chronological Bible, downloading apps like YouVersion, or supplementing your reading with commentaries. You can also listen to Scripture, letting its truths sink in during your daily routines.

- Meditation and Memorization

Reflect deeply on Scripture and commit key verses to memory. Even short passages such as Jesus wept can reveal profound truths when meditated upon. Allow these truths to saturate your thoughts and guide your actions.

- Interactive Practices

Engage with Scripture creatively through prayer, singing, journaling, and studying. As Colossians 3:16 reminds us, “Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly, teaching and admonishing one another in all wisdom, singing psalms and hymns and spiritual songs, with thankfulness in your hearts to God” (NIV).

God’s Word is not only life-giving; it’s a joy to savor daily. How will you delight in the bread of heaven today?

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## Devotion to Prayer

The early church's commitment to prayer underscores its vital role in the believer's life. Prayer is more than a religious activity; it's a relational exchange—a conversation with God where we speak to Him and listen for His voice. This intimate dynamic mirrors the personal devotion of the early church, where prayer was central to their lives and communities.

Jesus' teaching in Matthew 6:6 beautifully captures the essence of personal, intimate prayer: "But when you pray, go into your room and shut the door and pray to your Father who is in secret. And your Father who sees in secret will reward you" (NIV).

Prayer doesn't require elaborate words or rituals; it's about sincere *communication* with God. I've found it helpful to cultivate a sense of His presence through worship and prayer journaling. Writing out questions or requests, reflecting on Scripture, and recording answers has made my conversations with God deeply relational.

One memorable practice that transformed my personal prayer life was placing a chair in my room and imagining Jesus sitting there. This simple act reminded me of His nearness and shifted my prayer from formal and mechanical to vibrant and personal.

(Just don't let anyone walk in and catch you talking to an empty chair!)

## The Power of Corporate Prayer

Early in my twenties, I was blessed to join a prayer and missions ministry that hosted night and day worship and prayer in Atlanta. In this setting, I encountered a prayer culture that mirrored the daily gathering of the early church more than any other ministry I've been part of. A large part of my ministry life has been shaped by the practice of the body gathering corporately for daily prayer that I have seen modeled by our ministry, which still sustains night and day worship and prayer unabated into its 20th year.

This ministry later became GateCity Church, which is a story for another time. However, I would be remiss not to mention the blessing that comes upon a person's life when daily devotion isn't just practiced personally but also corporately, as modeled by the early church. There is a supernatural sharpening that happens when believers gather daily to seek the Lord together. We sharpen one another, stir one another, protect one another, and spur one another on when we pray together.

This culture of prayer remains foundational in our families' lives and ministry. For example, my wife and daughter lead virtual weekly prayer meetings for GateCity Buckhead. When we planted our

church, it was non-negotiable to our team that it be steeped in a culture of prayer, birthed through seasons of gathering daily online for intercession.

Only heaven will reveal the full impact of these prayers, but I'm convinced that they've immeasurably impacted everything we've done. Similarly, the daily prayer gatherings of the early church weren't just a historical pattern—they remain a *model* for the church today to walk in unity, humility, and power.

## Prayer in Practice: Personal Stories of Devotion

Shortly before joining GateCity, I served at the Billy Graham Training Center, where I learned the power of simple instructions for new believers—read the Word daily, pray, join a church, and share your faith. As I encouraged others in these practices, I developed my own devotional rhythm, experiencing God's voice personally in Scripture and prayer. Most believers know to do this, but the power is in the doing—turning it into a life-altering habit of drawing near to God daily.

One profound moment happened in a mall food court. While I was reading my Bible and praying, a young man practicing new-age spirituality approached me. He saw light emanating from my Bible with his physical eyes and wanted to know what I was reading. This opened the door to a conversation about the Gospel, and he



eventually became a Christian and joined our church. This experience reminded me of the supernatural power of God that's released when we engage with His Word and prayer.

Beyond moments like these, there are countless stories of transformation rooted in prayer. Both personal and corporate prayer have been the foundation for fruitfulness and breakthrough in my life and ministry. When we draw near to God, He draws near to us (James 4:8), and this promise is realized in the hidden moments of prayer—whether alone in a quiet room or surrounded by the voices of others crying out to God.

I believe that a culture of prayer does more than sustain a ministry; it transforms lives. It calls us into deeper intimacy with God, unites us as the body of Christ, and opens the way for supernatural breakthrough. It's my hope and prayer that we'll model the daily devotion of the early church—a people fully surrendered to God, both in personal and corporate prayer.

## Practices to Deepen Prayer

- Scripture-based Prayers

Use the prayers of the Bible, like the Psalms or Paul's apostolic prayers, to align your heart with God's will.

- Listening Prayer

Spend time in silence, listening for God's voice. Journaling impressions or thoughts can help you discern His guidance.

- Specific Requests

Bring specific needs to God with faith and expectancy.

Witnessing answered prayers strengthens trust in His power and responsiveness.

Prayer transforms not only our hearts, but also the lives of those around us. How can you cultivate a deeper awareness of God's presence in your own prayer life today?

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## Devotion to Fellowship

Fellowship is an essential expression of devotion that reveals our love for one another. As Jesus said in John 13:35, "By this all people will know that you are my disciples, if you have love for one another" (NIV).

Fellowship goes beyond simply attending church services. It calls for intentional relationships where believers encourage, support, and challenge one another in faith. The early church's shared meals, prayers, and resources reflect a deep commitment to unity and mutual care.

## The Transforming Power of Authentic Fellowship

In 2010, I joined a small group of men that would profoundly shape my life. Their fellowship became a source of strength and transformation, providing a safe and authentic community for confession, accountability, and practical support during life's most challenging and joyful seasons.

I vividly recall the day of my father's funeral. Two of these men were the ones who gathered around me, laid hands on me, and prayed with such sincerity and love that I felt the presence of God and the support of His body in a way I hadn't experienced before.

In addition, this same group of friends allowed me to walk with them through their own life transitions—whether navigating career changes, facing serious illnesses within their families, or celebrating the joys of stepping into marriage or of welcoming children into the world. These relationships didn't just emerge overnight; they were *cultivated* over years of shared experiences, honest conversations, and intentional time together.

What I've learned is that the hardest time to cultivate authentic friendships is in the middle of a storm. But when you've

already walked through seasons of joy and struggle together, those bonds become lifelines when the inevitable trials of life come. These men rejoiced with me in my victories and mourned with me in my losses, embodying the kind of fellowship God designed us to experience in community.

However, this kind of authentic fellowship isn't easy to accomplish—it requires perseverance, intentionality, and investment. Like anything of Kingdom value, it often involves trying, failing, and trying again. Building deep relationships takes time and effort, and there will undoubtedly be setbacks along the way. But we can take heart in knowing that God is faithful to help us form the connections we need.

When we commit to the process, He shapes relationships that not only support us in this life but endure even unto eternity. These bonds become a reflection of His eternal love and a glimpse of the fellowship we'll one day share in His presence.

## Practices to Build Authentic Fellowship

- Participate in Weekly Gatherings

Regular worship and small groups help strengthen connections with other believers.

- Serve One Another

Acts of service reflect Christ's sacrificial love and nurture community bonds.

- Foster Authentic Relationships

Transparency and accountability within a community encourage genuine spiritual growth.

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## Communion as a Picture of Devotion

Lastly, I want to highlight how communion—a regular practice in the life of the early church—beautifully encapsulates the themes of the Word, prayer, and fellowship. When we partake of the bread, we remember Christ's sacrifice and His Word made flesh (John 1:14), nourishing our spirits as we reflect on His life-giving truth. The cup reminds us of His blood shed for our forgiveness, drawing us into repentance, renewal, and a deeper connection with God and others.

Communion isn't merely a ritual; it's a unifying act that binds believers together in shared devotion to Christ. It calls us to remain steadfast in fellowship, celebrating our unity in Him,

and reaffirming our commitment to live out His love. Through this sacred practice, we're reminded of the centrality of the Word, the power of prayer, and the beauty of community in our walk with God.

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## Reflection and Application

Where is God calling you to renew your commitment to devotion? Is He inviting you into deeper engagement with His Word, a richer prayer life, or stronger fellowship with other believers?

The early church modeled a life of steadfast devotion, and we're called to follow in their footsteps. Take a moment to reflect on where God may be asking you to grow. Pray, seek His guidance, and perhaps even partake in communion as a way to reaffirm your commitment. Let the bread and cup remind you of His sacrifice, His Word, and the unity we share as His body.

May it be said of us that we have lives of depth in the Word, prayer, and fellowship, and that we allowed these devotions to transform us—strengthening our faith and overflowing into a love for one another that glorifies Christ. Together, let's

embrace the joy and power of living a devoted life, one that reflects the beauty of the Kingdom to the world.

# Chapter 5

## Power

### The Spirit's Power in the Early Church

In this chapter, we'll explore how the early church moved in the power of the Spirit. These early believers were a committed group who had accepted the saving power of Jesus Christ, experienced a transformational encounter with the Holy Spirit, and were baptized both with water and the Spirit. Their lives were marked by devotion to prayer, fellowship, the Word, and a lifestyle defined by deep love for God and one another—fulfilling the greatest commandments to love God and others.

This foundational devotion didn't stop at personal transformation. It naturally overflowed into the lives of others through the power of the Spirit. As Paul reminds us in 1 Thessalonians 1:5, "Our gospel came to you not simply with words but also with power, with the Holy Spirit and deep conviction" (NIV). The early church embodied this truth, living with the understanding that the gospel is more than a message—it's the power of God made *visible* through Spirit-filled lives.



When we've tasted God's transformational power, we're compelled to share it. The early church understood this deeply, living with an expectation that God's Spirit would empower them to minister with boldness and effectiveness. What might it look like for us today to walk in that same Spirit-filled devotion and expectant faith?

## The Power of the Spirit for All Believers

The power of the Spirit isn't reserved for leaders, but is for *every* believer. Acts 2:43 tells us, "Everyone was filled with awe at the many wonders and signs" (NIV). This wasn't theoretical, but tangible. For example, in Acts 3, a man lame from birth is healed, leaping and praising God in the temple courts.

Picture the scene. A man who had spent his entire life in the dust, utterly dependent on others, sits by the Beautiful Gate of the temple. His days are filled with the monotony of begging, eyes cast down, waiting for scraps of human pity. But then, Peter and John come near. Instead of brushing past him like countless others, they stop and fix their gaze on him. "Look at us," Peter commands, his voice firm yet full of compassion. The man looks up, expecting a coin, but instead hears these electrifying words:— "Silver or gold I do not have, but what I do have I give you. In the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth, walk" (NIV).

Instantly, something unimaginable happens. Peter reaches out, grabs the man's hand, and pulls him up. Strength floods his legs—legs that had *never* known the weight of his own body. When his feet and ankles become firm, he takes a tentative step, then another. Disbelief melts into awe as he begins to leap, his laughter mingling with shouts of praise.

However, the crowd around him freezes, their daily routines shattered by this miracle. They recognize him instantly—the beggar who had sat helplessly at the gate for years—now dancing, weeping, and shouting praises to God. Murmurs swell into an uproar. "What just happened? How is this possible?"

This man's life is utterly transformed in a moment. He enters the temple for the first time not as a beggar but as a worshiper, his body and soul now a living testimony of the power of Jesus. The crowd's awe is palpable, their wonder at what they've witnessed stirring a hunger to know the source of this miraculous power. This isn't just healing; it's a declaration that the Kingdom of God is breaking into their midst.

This miraculous power, displayed through the early leaders of the church, is available to us today.

To unlock God's power in our lives, we need three practical steps: (1) have the right expectation, (2) step out of our comfort zones, and (3) persevere in practice. Let's examine each step more closely.

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## Practical Steps to Unlock the Spirit's Power

### 1. Having the Right Expectation

The first step is having the right expectation, which begins with believing that God's power is available and is willing to work through us. For many, the challenge is overcoming doubt or past disappointments. Have you ever prayed for something, believed as much as you could, and not seen the result you hoped for? It's in these moments that trusting God's word over our own experiences becomes critical.

The Bible reminds us that faith comes by *hearing* the word of God (Romans 10:17). Begin by immersing yourself in Scriptures about God's power and promises. For example, Acts 1:8 assures us that, "You will receive power when the Holy Spirit comes on you" (NIV). Let that promise shape your expectation.

For those struggling with skepticism, consider this. Even when we don't understand why some prayers seem unanswered, we're called

to believe in God's goodness and trust His timing. As Deuteronomy 29:29 says, "The secret things belong to the Lord our God" (NIV).

On a practical level, as we'll cover in detail in the next step, start small. Pray for someone with a headache or a simple need. You might say, "God, I trust you to heal this," and let the outcome rest in *His* hands. It's not about what *we* can do, but about inviting Him to move.

## 2. Practicing with Expectation: Taking Small Risks

The second step is to *act* on that expectation by stepping out of your comfort zone. It's not enough to believe in God's power; we need to create opportunities for Him to work. For instance, consider moments in your daily life where you might pray for someone or share an encouraging word. Perhaps a colleague shares that they're feeling overwhelmed, and instead of saying, "I'll keep you in my thoughts," you offer to pray with them right there.

Small risks can lead to profound encounters. For instance, I'll never forget the story of my friend who felt prompted to ask the hostess at a restaurant he was dining at if he could pray for her. He felt awkward about it, but couldn't shake the 'divine nudge' and asked her if he could pray for her right then and there.

Suddenly, she burst into tears. What only God knew was that she was battling intense depression and planning to take her own life.

However on her recent break, she had prayed, asking God to send her a sign. In that moment, His simple step of uncomfortable obedience became a lifeline and a sign of God's love to this young woman.

Skeptics might wonder, "What if nothing happens?" Remember, *your* role isn't to guarantee results, but to faithfully act in love and obedience. God's power works in His way and His time. Even when you don't see immediate results, your step of faith can plant a seed in someone's heart.

### 3. Persevering in Practice: Embracing Mystery

The final step is perseverance, which is perhaps the hardest because it requires staying faithful even when outcomes are inconsistent or unclear. Some prayers are answered dramatically, while others seem to go unanswered. It's in this tension that we must embrace the mystery of God's ways.

One member of our short term team in Uganda prayed for a woman with a swollen abdomen. When she stood up after prayer, the swelling and discomfort was gone, and she testified before the church, "I've been healed!" The joy in that room was remarkable. Yet, the same day, they prayed for literally hundreds of others who didn't see immediate results. This can be disheartening, but

perseverance means choosing to pray again and believe again, trusting that God is at work even when we can't see it immediately.

For those who feel fatigued and discouraged by the uncertainty of God's supernatural ways, remember Galatians 6:9. "Let us not grow weary in doing good, for at the proper time we will reap a harvest if we do not give up" (NIV). Our job is to pray with sincere faith, and His job is to answer! Perseverance is about continuing to show up, trusting that each prayer and step of faith is contributing to something bigger than what we can ever see at a given moment.

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## Testimony: The Power of God in Everyday Struggles

I want to share a story that vividly demonstrates how the power of the Holy Spirit works in ways we often don't expect, addressing even deeply personal struggles. It's a reminder that God's care extends to *every* part of our lives, no matter how hidden or insignificant it may feel to us.

During an altar call, a young woman felt prompted to respond, though she later admitted to me, "I felt this light sensation, almost like electricity, in my feet. I thought, 'Lord, I don't want to go up

there again.” She had already responded in the previous service and wrestled with what others might think if they saw her come forward twice. But ultimately, she said, “I knew the Lord wanted me to go, so I did.”

As she worshiped, I felt a prompting to pray into certain struggles people in the room might be facing. I had no idea who it might apply to, but as I began praying about ‘body image issues,’ I happened to have my hand on her shoulder. I had no knowledge of her specific struggles—it was simply an impression from the Holy Spirit.

Later, she came to me and shared, “When you said that, it struck me deeply. I’ve been struggling with body image so much. I lost a lot of weight but hit a plateau months ago, and it’s been so discouraging.” She explained how her frustration had turned into an unhealthy obsession. “I’d look at myself in the mirror constantly, dreaming of being 30 pounds lighter. It consumed me.”

In that moment, God used a simple prayer to speak directly to her heart, reassuring her that she was seen and valued just as she was. She told me, “God ministered to me through your words, even though you didn’t know what I was dealing with. It brought me so much freedom.”

Her encounter with the Holy Spirit didn't just challenge her view of herself—it also transformed her understanding of how God works. She said, “This showed me that God cares about areas I didn't think were important enough to bring to Him. It also challenged what I believed about how the Holy Spirit operates today. I'm so grateful for how God showed up for me.”

Her testimony reminds me that the Holy Spirit is as active here as He is anywhere else in the world. When I've preached in places like Uganda, our team has seen remarkable demonstrations of the Spirit's power—healings, deliverances, and bold encounters with God's presence. However this story, from a youth ministry in the city where my wife grew up, is a powerful reminder that God moves wherever His people are willing to believe, respond, and invite Him to work.

This young woman's experience highlights the relevance of God's power in addressing struggles many people face in our culture—body image issues, mental health challenges, and questions of self-worth. It's a reminder that the same Spirit who heals bodies also heals hearts, revealing His deep care and bringing freedom to the hidden places of our lives.

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## Reflection and Application

If you've never experienced God's power moving through your life like this, begin by raising your expectations. Pray for opportunities to lay hands on the sick, share prophetic encouragement, or speak bold truths to those in need. Be intentional and persistent, even when the results seem mixed.

The early church's testimony—marked by boldness, unified prayer, and miraculous signs—should inspire us to *contend* for the same in our lives and communities. The Spirit's power isn't just meant to be talked about, but demonstrated as the reality of God, confirming the gospel message and drawing others to Christ.

As Paul declared, "My message and my preaching were not with wise and persuasive words, but with a demonstration of the Spirit's power, so that your faith might not rest on human wisdom, but on God's power" (1 Cor. 2:4-5, NIV).

The Spirit's work is beautifully illustrated in Luke 4:18, where Jesus proclaims, "The Spirit of the Lord is on me, because he has anointed me to proclaim good news to the poor. He has sent me to proclaim freedom for the prisoners and recovery of sight for the blind, to set the oppressed free" (NIV). This same Holy Spirit is now with us!

The life and ministry of Jesus was birthed, empowered, and fulfilled in the Spirit's power. By raising our expectations, stepping out of our comfort zones, and persevering in faith, we position ourselves to experience God's power just as the early church did.

As we walk in this power, let's remember that the Spirit's work isn't about elevating our status, but about *glorifying* Christ. Through the Holy Spirit, we become vessels of His love, conduits of His grace, and witnesses of His Kingdom breaking into the world.

May we hold fast to His promises, trusting Him in every step and every unanswered question. Let's be bold in faith, humble in service, and relentless in pursuing the fullness of God's power for the sake of His glory and the good of others.

# Chapter 6

## Unity

### Unity—The Call to Oneness

Unity isn't just an ideal; it's a divine mandate. As we see in Acts 2:40-46, the early church understood this deeply. Believers were described as being of one heart and mind, sharing *all* they had while living in daily close relationships with one another. Verse 44 highlights this. "All the believers were together and had everything in common" (NIV). This passage not only describes the *power* of unity, but sets a standard for what the church is called to embody—a unity that reflects the very nature of God.

This chapter explores the significance of unity, both as a biblical principle and a practical pursuit. It draws on my personal experiences—first as an organizer of prayer and evangelistic efforts in Atlanta, then as a key leader in the OneRace Movement (OneRace), and finally as a pastor called to build a local church that reflects the unity God desires for His people. Through these stories and the lens of Scripture, we'll examine why unity is so critical and how we, as the church, can pursue it.

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## Unity in Jesus' High Priestly Prayer

When we think of unity, we need to begin with Jesus' high priestly prayer in John 17. On the eve of His crucifixion, Jesus could've prayed for anything. Yet, He prayed *four* times for His Church to be one. "That they may be one as we are one" (John 17:22, NIV).

This prayer reveals God's heart for His people to be united in the same way that the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit are united within the Trinity. The unity of the Godhead—perfect in love, purpose, and harmony—is meant to be mirrored in the church. When Jesus prayed this, He was praying the perfect will of God. And we can rest assured that His prayer will ultimately be answered. Yet, this unity isn't reserved for eternity; it's a calling for today.

However, the stakes are high. Jesus linked unity directly to our witness. "By this everyone will know that you are my disciples if you love one another" (John 13:35, NIV). A united church testifies to the truth of the gospel. Conversely, division undermines our credibility and hinders the work of God.

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## My Journey Toward Unity

In 2016, unity became a personal conviction during an evangelistic effort. As the organizer of prayer initiatives leading up to a large multi-day crusade in a 15,000-seat arena, I felt the weight of gathering believers from across denominations and cultures to pray. Just days before the event, I sought a final location for prayer, but found no available space near the stadium. In desperation, I prayed, and the Holy Spirit gave me a vision of the Center for Civil and Human Rights, just blocks away.

As I saw this picture in my mind's eye, I sensed God saying, "The harvest you desire to see in this city is on the other side of a unified church." It was a revelation—the church's ability to reap a spiritual harvest is directly tied to its unity. While renting space at the center, believers from various backgrounds gathered to pray for hours. That experience set me on a path to pursue unity as a foundational principle for revival and outreach.

Later that summer, in the wake of national tragedies like the Dallas police officer shooting and the death of Philando Castile, pastors across Atlanta began meeting to pray in consideration of these injustices. My pastor, Billy Humphrey, invited me to help organize these meetings. Soon, I found myself in an operational role, alongside my good friend Josh Clemons, coordinating gatherings that would eventually grow into the OneRace Movement.

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## OneRace Stone Mountain: Repentance and Reconciliation

On August 25, 2018, we gathered for a city-wide day of prayer at Stone Mountain, the historic birthplace of the Ku Klux Klan, where the first cross was burned in 1915. That first cross burning was led by a minister. Therefore, we began the day with a powerful act of repentance led by pastors. Over 250 pastors and 3,000 young people ascended Stone Mountain, a granite hill that rises 800 feet over the landscape of suburban Atlanta.

Not only is the mountain the historic place of the clan re-birth and their frequent blasphemous quasi-religious rituals, it also has carved into its face the world's largest monument to the confederacy depictions of Jefferson Davis, General Jackson, and General Lee. At the top of this mountain, pastors led a solemn moment of public repentance, asking forgiveness for the church's complicity in racism and division, and erected a crimson and white draped cross as a symbol of our unity and repentance.

Following this act, we descended the mountain for an ongoing day of worship, teaching, and prayer at the base. The gathering culminated with a moment of communion, as thousands of

believers from different races and denominations broke bread together, declaring the love and justice of God over our city and nation. Over 25,000 people participated that day, demonstrating the power of unity to heal and transform.

This event, held at such a symbolic location, was a declaration that the church would no longer be silent or divided. It was a public commitment to reconciliation and justice, rooted in the gospel.

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## Practical Steps Toward Unity

Though this event was powerful, we knew that there was still so much work to be done. Unity doesn't happen by accident. It requires intentionality, sacrifice, and obedience to God's Word. Here are some practical steps to foster unity in the church that OneRace Movement still helps equip and train pastors to walk out today.

- Pursue Humility

Unity begins with humility. Paul writes in Philippians 2:3-4, "Do nothing out of selfish ambition or vain conceit. Rather, in humility value others above yourselves, not looking to your own interests but each of you to the interests of the others" (NIV). Humility creates space for reconciliation and mutual understanding.

- Commit to Forgiveness

Forgiveness is essential for unity. Ephesians 4:32 reminds us to, “Be kind and compassionate to one another, forgiving each other, just as in Christ God forgave you” (NIV).

Unforgiveness builds walls, but forgiveness tears them down.

- Prioritize Relationships

The early church met daily in homes and the temple, sharing meals and lives (Acts 2:46). True unity requires *intentional* relationships. Make time to connect with believers who are different from you, building bridges across cultural, racial, and denominational lines.

- Pray for Unity

Prayer aligns our hearts with God’s. Jesus Himself prayed for unity in John 17, and we should follow His example.

Regularly intercede for unity in your church, city, and nation.

- Celebrate Diversity

Unity is not uniformity. Revelation 7:9 gives us a picture of heaven. “A great multitude...from every nation, tribe, people and language, standing before the throne” (NIV). The church is enriched by its diversity; therefore, seek to honor and celebrate it.



- Work for Justice  
Unity needs to be paired with justice. Isaiah 1:17 says, “Learn to do right; seek justice. Defend the oppressed” (NIV). True unity addresses systemic injustice and seeks the flourishing of all people.
  - Preach and Practice the Gospel  
The gospel is the ultimate unifier. As we proclaim the message of salvation through Jesus Christ, we also need to live it out in love, service, and sacrifice.
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## March on Atlanta: A Vision of the Unified Church

Two years later, on Juneteenth 2020, during the height of the pandemic and national unrest, OneRace hosted another event called the March on Atlanta. Over 15,000 believers marched from Centennial Olympic Park to the Georgia State Capitol, calling for justice and unity. Another 200,000 joined via livestream.

At the conclusion of the march, as thousands worshiped together, I stood on stage and heard the Holy Spirit whisper, “Build me a church that looks like this.” Instantly, I was in tears. Up to that moment, I had served as a prayer leader and organizer of

reconciliation movements, but now I felt a personal calling to pioneer a new church work.

As I looked out over that worshiping crowd, several defining qualities stood out to me:

- Multi-ethnic: Reflecting the diversity of God's creation.
- Multi-generational: Embracing wisdom from the past and energy for the future.
- Standing for justice: Serving as a public witness to the city.
- Passionate in worship and abandoned in prayer: Cultivating a vibrant expression of faith.

This vision has become the foundation for the church plant my wife and I now lead. Moreover, it continues to shape my understanding of unity in the body of Christ.

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## The Future of Unity in the Church

Unity is *both* a gift and a calling, which reflects the nature of God, fulfills the prayer of Jesus, and empowers the church to carry out its mission. As I look back on the thousands gathered at OneRace Stone Mountain and the March on Atlanta, I see a glimpse of what

the Church can be—a diverse, united body, worshiping God and working for His purposes.

However, unity isn't just a vision for large gatherings; it's a daily commitment. Unity is found in the small acts of love, forgiveness, and humility that bring us closer together as the body of Christ. May we, like the early church, devote ourselves to this call, so that the world may know we're *His* disciples and believe in the One who sent Him.

Acts 2:44 reminds us that “All the believers were together and had everything in common” (NIV). Let this verse serve as both a memory and a mandate, calling us back to the unity that reflects the heart of God.

# Chapter 7

## Generosity—The God Who Gives

Acts 2:40-46 provides a profound glimpse into the heart of a Spirit-filled community—a family of believers transformed by God’s generous nature. Verse 44 states that, “All the believers were together and had everything in common” (NIV). This is no small statement! It speaks of a radical unity expressed in selfless generosity. They sold possessions, met needs, and lived in such a way that no one among them lacked anything. Their lives mirrored the heart of God, a heart that’s defined by giving.

However, this generosity didn’t come from human effort. It was the *overflow* of encountering the God who gives, a God whose generosity knows no bounds. The early church’s way of life was a reflection of the God they worshipped—a God who gives sacrificially, abundantly, and joyfully.

My wife Hannah shared a story during a message that captures the essence of this chapter and reveals something of God’s nature through a personal encounter. During our 2023 mission trip to Uganda that we’ve referenced often in this book, our family had the

opportunity to hike an extinct volcano near Mbale. As we ascended, we came across a series of three waterfalls cascading down the slopes, each larger and more magnificent than the last. By the time we reached the final one, we were awestruck.

Hannah described walking toward the last waterfall where the rush of water was so powerful it created its own wind. Mist filled the air, obscuring her vision and soaking everything around her. It was impossible to stand close without being overwhelmed by the sheer force of the spray and the sound of the water crashing down. In that moment, she saw the waterfall as a metaphor for God's generous love—a torrential, unceasing outpouring that *never* runs dry.

She reflected, “This is what God's generosity is like. It's not a trickle or even a river—it's a waterfall, always pouring forth, always refreshing, always reaching the lowest places. It doesn't stop when someone walks away or when no one is looking. It's constant, powerful, and life-giving.”

This waterfall image sets the stage for understanding the generosity of God. His giving is abundant and unstoppable, a reflection of His very nature. As Hannah stood at the base of that waterfall, she felt the cool, refreshing mist washing over her. It reminded her of the way God's love continually refreshes us, even in life's dry and weary places.

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## God's Generosity: Creator and Sustainer

The story of God's generosity begins long before humanity ever existed. Before time itself, God—the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit—dwelt in perfect unity, love, and joy. Theologians call this relationship the *perichoresis*, the divine dance of love within the Trinity. In this perfect community, there was no need, no lack. Yet, out of the overflow of His generous heart, God created.

Psalm 19:1 says, “The heavens declare the glory of God; the skies proclaim the work of His hands” (NIV). Creation *itself* is an expression of God's giving nature. He didn't create out of necessity, but as an act of love, inviting humanity into the dance of fellowship with Him. Every star in the sky, every mountain peak, and every rushing waterfall testifies to the God who gives.

God's generosity didn't stop at creation. He continues to sustain life moment by moment. “You open Your hand and satisfy the desires of every living thing” (Psalm 145:16, NIV). In Matthew 5:45, it reminds us that God causes the sun to rise and the rain to fall on *both* the righteous and the unrighteous.

In addition, His generosity isn't selective; it's extended to all. The perception of this generosity has shaped me from my earliest days, as

it was in knowing God as creator that I came to the conviction of His realness, love, and power.

Even now, Hebrews 1:3 tells us that Jesus, “...sustains all things by His powerful word...” (NIV). This sustaining love is a continual act of giving. Every breath we take and every beat of our hearts is evidence of God’s generosity. We remain alive because He wills it, and His hand is open to provide for all our needs.

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## The Ultimate Gift and Giver: Jesus

The pinnacle of God’s generosity is found in the gift of His Son. Romans 8:32 declares, “He who did not spare His own Son, but gave Him up for us all—how will He not also, along with Him, graciously give us all things?” (NIV). God didn’t withhold His very best. He gave Jesus as a sacrificial offering so that we could be *reconciled* to Him.

This act of giving wasn’t transactional—it was deeply personal and costly. God gave His Son to a world that didn’t deserve Him, demonstrating that generosity is central to who He is. As Hannah said in her message, “God isn’t self-protecting or holding back. He delights in giving, even when it costs Him everything.”

When Jesus walked the earth, He perfectly modeled the generosity of the Father. In every interaction, He displayed open-heartedness—toward the Father, His community, strangers, and even His enemies. Through His actions, Jesus revealed how we, too, can live generously.

## Toward the Father

Jesus demonstrated generosity toward the Father by living in complete submission to His will. He declared, “The Son can do nothing by Himself; He can only do what He sees His Father doing” (John 5:19, NIV). By prioritizing God’s plans above His own desires, Jesus modeled a heart fully open to the Father’s purposes.

## Practical Application

We can emulate this by dedicating time each day to prayer, asking for guidance in our decisions. Trusting in God’s wisdom might mean setting aside personal ambitions to pursue a calling that benefits others, even when it feels uncomfortable or uncertain.

## Toward His Community

Jesus was generous with His time, energy, and presence in His relationships. He shared meals, welcomed children, and built meaningful connections. In Matthew 19, when the disciples tried to



stop parents from bringing their children to Him, Jesus replied, “Let the little children come to Me” (NIV). This act of generosity created space for others to experience His love.

## Practical Application

Following Jesus’ example could look like intentionally reaching out to friends, family, or church members in need of encouragement. Hosting a meal, volunteering at community events, or offering to babysit for a busy parent are tangible ways to reflect His love.

## Toward Strangers

Jesus extended generosity to strangers by crossing boundaries of culture and societal norms to meet their needs. In John 4, He engaged the Samaritan woman at the well, offering her ‘living water’ and revealing her worth in God’s eyes. His actions remind us to extend kindness and dignity to those we don’t know, especially those *marginalized* by society.

## Practical Application

Practicing generosity toward strangers might involve serving at a homeless shelter, donating to a refugee support organization, or simply showing kindness to someone in line at the grocery store.

Being open to conversations with people outside our social circles is a powerful way to model Jesus' inclusivity.

## Toward His Enemies

On the cross, Jesus offered the ultimate act of generosity by praying for His enemies. "Father, forgive them, for they do not know what they are doing" (Luke 23:34, NIV). Even in His suffering, He *chose* love and forgiveness over retaliation.

## Practical Application

We can follow this example by choosing to forgive those who've wronged us, even when it's hard. Writing a letter of reconciliation, praying for others who have hurt us, doing a kind act for them, or literally forgiving a financial debt can help us embody Jesus' forgiveness and love toward those who would mistreat and use us.

In every aspect of His life, Jesus showed us that true generosity *flows* from a heart aligned with God's love. By following His example, we can live lives that reflect the open-hearted generosity of Christ.

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## A Generous Answer to Prayer

After visiting the dentist for the first time in a few years, Hannah and I were shocked to learn that we each had many cavities. We were kicking ourselves for not regularly getting our teeth cleaned and felt like we were suffering the consequences of our own irresponsibility. The total bill to fix our cavities was eye-popping—over \$10,000. We were young in ministry and lived off the support we raised for our ministry. Needless to say, we couldn't solve this mess (of our own doing) on our own. In our need, we asked God for help.

Only a few weeks later, we were praying for a new visitor (a stranger to us), and I had a picture for her that her teeth were gleaming. I interpreted it as a prophetic encouragement that she would have wisdom and an ability to digest the word. She started to laugh! While my interpretation may have been accurate, it was also literal. She and her husband had just opened a dental practice locally. After we finished prayer, she offered to give us any dental care we needed for free.

We warned her she didn't know what she was getting into! However, they kindly had us come in to see how bad it was. She confirmed we needed a lot of work, but she and her husband decided to generously

come in on their day off and get all our teeth taken care of! They remain our dentists to this day.

Ever since, Hannah and I have walked out 'repentance' with regular cleanings. As a result, we've been blessed by the generosity of these strangers who now have been our friends for over 10 years.

At the time, I wasn't only in awe of our friends' generosity of time and skill to meet our need, but also of the kindness of God to make that supernatural connection in a moment of prayer and help me in an area where I felt like I had messed up. This example of God's generosity and that of His people has stayed with me and inspires Hannah and I to be the generous answer to the needs of others.

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## Historical Example: The Generosity of the Moravian Community

Under Count Zinzendorf's leadership, the Moravian community provides a profound historical example of a group of believers embodying the generosity and mutual care described in Acts 2:44-45 where "all who believed were together and had all things in common" (NIV). The Moravians not only met one another's needs, but also served as a light to the surrounding world through their radical commitment to generosity and shared mission.

Zinzendorf himself modeled this generosity through his personal sacrifices. He welcomed refugees to his estate in Herrnhut, Germany providing land, resources, and protection for those fleeing religious persecution in what is now the Czech Republic. His willingness to surrender his wealth and position for the sake of the gospel demonstrated his deep conviction that his resources ultimately belonged to God.

In a notable act of generosity, Zinzendorf not only supported the physical needs of the community, but also funded missionary efforts that extended the gospel to the farthest reaches of the world.

The Moravians followed his example by embracing a culture of shared responsibility and mutual provision. They organized their community life so that no one was left in need. Their practice of pooling resources reflected their understanding of stewardship—that what they had was not theirs alone, but a trust from God to be used for His purposes.

This approach fostered unity, reduced individual burdens, and allowed the community to focus collectively on their spiritual mission.

Their commitment to generosity is vividly captured in their 1727 Brotherly Agreement, which outlines their dedication to meeting the needs of the sick and needy:

"We will faithfully care for the poor and the sick among us, providing for their physical needs as God has blessed us, so that no one suffers want among the brethren."

This directive reflects their belief that generosity wasn't merely an *individual* virtue, but a *shared* responsibility. They prioritized ensuring that everyone in their community was supported, particularly the most vulnerable. The Brotherly Agreement further calls its members to take an active role in mutual aid:

"Each member shall regard the other's burdens as their own and shall willingly serve those in distress, whether through visitation, prayer, or material assistance."

The Moravians' intentional care for one another went beyond financial support. They were generous with their time, prayer, and talents, creating a culture where every individual was valued and cared for. By addressing both physical and spiritual needs, they embodied the love and unity described in Acts 2.

This model of generosity has inspired countless Christian communities throughout history, challenging believers to live out the radical generosity of the early church. The Moravians remind us that generosity isn't limited to financial giving, but encompasses the *totality* of our lives, as we steward all that God has entrusted to us for the sake of His kingdom.

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## Empowered to Reflect God's Generosity

The generosity we experienced from Christian strangers, that of the Moravians, and the early church's generosity in Acts 2 weren't just human achievements of kindness—it was the result of the Holy Spirit's work.

On Pentecost, God poured out His Spirit, empowering believers to live as Jesus did. Joel 2:28 had prophesied, “I will pour out My Spirit on all people” (NIV). This outpouring enabled the church to give sacrificially and joyfully, reflecting God's heart.

We, too, are called to reflect God's generosity. Ephesians 5:1-2 encourages us to, “Be imitators of God, as dearly loved children, and walk in the way of love, just as Christ loved us and gave Himself up for us as a fragrant offering” (NIV). Freely we have received, and freely we are to give (Matt. 10:8, NIV).

God's generosity calls us to live open-handedly. Whether forgiving an enemy, meeting the needs of a stranger, or sharing resources within our community, we're constantly invited to reflect His giving nature. Like the early church, we *can* create a community where no one is in need, where God's love flows freely through us.

Hannah's story of the waterfall is a powerful reminder of this invitation. Just as the waterfall poured out its life-giving water without ceasing, so God's generosity flows to us and through us. Let's stand in that mist, receive His love, and allow it to refresh and renew us. Then, let's pour it out to the world around us, reflecting the heart of the God who gives.



# Chapter 8

## Preparing the Way for Kingdom Culture

### Heralds: Proclaiming the Way for the King

The role of a herald in the ancient world was pivotal. Sent ahead of a conquering king, the herald's duty was to prepare the people for the king's arrival. This preparation wasn't simply logistical. It involved calling the people to align their lives and lands in readiness for their sovereign ruler.

Isaiah 40:3-5 (NLT) captures a profound calling of one who goes before a coming King.

“Listen! It's the voice of someone shouting, ‘Clear the way through the wilderness for the Lord! Make a straight highway through the wasteland for our God! Fill in the valleys, and level the mountains and hills. Straighten the curves, and smooth out the rough

places. Then the glory of the Lord will be revealed, and all people will see it together. The Lord has spoken!”

This passage prophesied specifically the ministry of John the Baptist, who came as a *messenger* to prepare Israel for their coming King. His calling was to spiritually make them ready to receive Jesus, their Messiah, by turning them away from their sins.

Yet as much as John affected the culture of his day, he was a peculiar character. Standing out against the backdrop of religious elites with their flowing robes and ornate traditions, John seemed more like a wild prophet from a bygone era.

For example, he wore a garment of rough camel’s hair, tied with a leather belt—a stark contrast to the fine linens of temple priests. His diet was equally strange—locusts and wild honey, the foraged food of someone who thrived outside society’s norms. His unkempt appearance, fiery voice, and wilderness dwelling made him look like he had stepped out of the pages of Israel’s ancient prophetic history.

To the refined, city-dwelling Pharisees, John must’ve seemed uncivilized and unsettling. Yet, people couldn’t ignore him. His passionate cries for repentance and his raw authenticity resonated deeply, drawing crowds from Jerusalem, Judea, and beyond. Despite his oddness—or perhaps because of it—John became the perfect

herald for the Messiah who would also defy expectations, bringing a kingdom unlike any they'd imagined.

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## Watchmen: Opening to the King

In addition, this first image of a herald is closely related to the role of the watchman at the gates of an ancient city. Where the herald went before a king, the watchman kept vigilant to open the gates when the procession of the victorious king arrived.

Psalm 24:7-10 (NLT) explains this imagery of our King being welcomed into Jerusalem, likely inspired by the arrival of the ark of the covenant.

“Open up, ancient gates! Open up ancient doors, and let the King of glory enter. Who is the King of glory? The Lord, strong and mighty; the Lord, invincible in battle. Open up, ancient gates! Open up ancient doors, and let the King of glory enter. Who is the King of glory? The Lord of Heaven’s Armies—he is the King of glory.”

The herald goes before our King, announcing His arrival to smooth the way, while the watchman ensures that His procession is met with honor and readiness with open gates. Both roles carry a

profound responsibility—to recognize, prepare, and welcome the King with reverence.

For the church today, these roles provide a powerful metaphor of her duties in proclamation and prayer. It's by these two legs that the gospel advances. As heralds, believers are called to proclaim the coming Kingdom and prepare the way for others to meet Jesus through communicating truth.

As watchmen, the church stands vigilant in prayer, aligning lives in purity and intimacy with God while remaining ready to intercede on behalf of others. Together, they challenge the church to transform culture by welcoming the King and inviting others to do the same. This is how we will impact culture—through gospel proclamation and intercession.

## The Tension Between Resistance and Submission

In the ancient world, resistance to an invading ruler often involved erecting barriers, digging trenches, tearing up roads to impede the conqueror's advance, and literally barricading the city gates. For example, during the Roman conquest of Judea in 66–70 A.D., Jewish rebels fortified cities and disrupted infrastructure in an effort to resist the Roman legions. These tactics highlighted their refusal to submit; however, ultimately their efforts led to devastating losses.

Isaiah's command to 'make straight' the way for the Lord presents a radical counterpoint. Instead of resistance, the nations are willingly called to prepare the way for our coming King. This preparation requires humility, surrender, and the removal of any obstacles that might hinder his arrival.

For the church, this means living in a way that invites Christ's rule rather than resisting it. Just as John the Baptist prepared the way for Jesus by calling people to repentance, the church is called to confront cultural resistance with truth and love, opening the gates of both hearts and cities to the King of Glory.

A vivid example of this is found in the life of Girolamo Savonarola, a 15th-century Italian Dominican monk. Like John the Baptist, Savonarola lived a life of deep prayer and asceticism, fasting regularly and devoting hours to intercession. He became renowned for his fiery sermons, which he delivered with uncompromising passion, denouncing the corruption of both church and state leaders in Florence. "Repent, for the scourge of the Lord is coming," he once proclaimed, urging the people to turn from their excesses and seek God.

Under his influence, Florence underwent a remarkable transformation. Citizens abandoned their indulgences and burned items associated with vanity and sin, such as luxurious clothing,

books, and artwork. His leadership inspired reforms that sought to align the city's governance with godly principles.

However, his unrelenting boldness eventually drew powerful enemies, including Pope Alexander VI. Declared a heretic, Savonarola was arrested, tortured, and ultimately hanged and burned in 1498.

Savonarola's life exemplifies the tension of living counter to the culture while profoundly impacting society for the Kingdom of God. His story reminds us that faithfulness to God's truth may come at great personal cost, but can leave a lasting spiritual legacy.

Today, the church is called to emulate this model, serving as watchmen in prayer, heralds proclaiming the coming Kingdom, and living these countercultural values in the midst. This calling puts believers in a constant position of tension.

For example, the church must reject the idolization of material wealth and practice radical generosity, even when society prioritizes accumulation and individualism. It must stand for the sanctity of all human life and the dignity of every person, even when cultural narratives devalue certain groups.

Additionally, above all else, the Church must uphold the truth of the deity of Jesus and the truth of God's Word, which are foundational to its mission and identity. While it's sometimes easy

to capitulate to that tension and shrink back to practice faith only behind closed doors or stumble in the other direction and compromise by forsaking righteous living, we must remain steadfast.

As a body, we must proclaim the gospel boldly, pray fervently, and embody Christ's transformative power. This way of life will prepare the way for Jesus to be received in hearts, homes, and communities. In the next chapter, we'll expand on these same ideas, exploring practical ways to live them out in the midst of cultural opposition.

## Thy Kingdom Come

The church's prayer, "...thy kingdom come, thy will be done, on earth as it is in heaven" (Matt. 6:10, KJV), bridges the present mission of the church with the future fullness of the Kingdom. Revelation 19:11-14 (NLT) offers a dramatic vision of this ultimate fulfillment.

"Then I saw heaven opened, and a white horse was standing there. Its rider was named Faithful and True, for he judges fairly and wages a righteous war. His eyes were like flames of fire, and on his head were many crowns. A name was written on him that no one understood except himself. He wore a robe dipped in blood, and his title was the Word of God. The armies

of heaven, dressed in the finest of pure white linen,  
followed him on white horses.”

While we eagerly await Christ’s return as the conquering King, we’re called to embody His Kingdom now, just as the early church did in Acts 2. Through prayer, repentance, generosity, and courageous engagement with the world’s brokenness, we declare His Lordship and prepare the way for His coming.

As we live as heralds and watchmen—praying, serving, and proclaiming His truth—we manifest the hope of Christ in a world longing for redemption. In both our present faithfulness and our future hope, we echo the prayer of the church through the ages—”Come, Lord Jesus” (Rev. 22:20, NIV). We’re not just preparing people to go to heaven, but preparing the earth for Jesus and His Kingdom to come to earth.

## Cultural Impact Through Transformation

The early church exemplifies what it means to *impact* culture through proclamation and prayer. Their authority, much like that of John the Baptist, was rooted in their non-conformity. They lived in the tension of physical and relational proximity to those they wanted to influence with God’s message.

Acts 2:38-46 shows how salvation, devotion to God, the power of the Holy Spirit, unity among believers, and generosity led to favor



with *all* the people. This cultural impact led to the growth of the church, as the Lord added *daily* to those who were being saved. Without an impact in the culture that draws the lost, healthy growth is unattainable.

The church's influence extended beyond its immediate community inside the 'walls' of the church because the strength of that community overflowed into the 'streets.' As believers shared their lives with others, their countercultural practices of generosity, hospitality, and unity stood out in stark contrast to the fragmented, self-serving society around them. Their commitment to truth called the culture to repentance, while inviting others to experience the goodness of God's saving power.

If we want to help align the lives of others, we need to first ensure our own lives are aligned.

- Where are we actively resisting God's leadership?
- Where have we closed the door of our hearts instead of opening it?

In Revelation 3:20, Jesus says, "Look! I stand at the door and knock. If you hear my voice and open the door, I will come in, and we will share a meal together as friends" (NIV). Picture this moment. The King of kings, standing at the door, His knock steady and filled with patient love, His voice gentle yet compelling. His presence radiates

both majesty and invitation, a divine yearning for intimacy and fellowship. He doesn't force entry, but waits patiently with the promise of communion.

Turning away from sin begins with acknowledging areas where we've shut Jesus out. For instance, it may look like surrendering a grudge that has hardened our hearts or confessing hidden habits that distance us from God.

Daily fellowship with Jesus can start simply such as spending quiet moments in prayer each morning, reading His Word with expectation, and practicing gratitude throughout the day. For example, instead of scrolling through social media before bed, we might *choose* to meditate on a psalm or journal a prayer. Over time, these small steps open the door wider for Him to transform our hearts.

Tragically, many leave Jesus outside, hearing the knock yet hesitating to respond. However, to those who open the door, He promises not just a visit, but a transformative fellowship—a relationship that changes how we live, think, and love. We need to welcome Him into our hearts and lives *fully*, for only then can we truly invite Him into our cities and communities.

# Chapter 9

## Cultural Impact

### The Fulton Street Revival

The Fulton Street Revival of 1857-59, also called the Businessman's Revival, offers a powerful example of how *everyday* people can be impacted by a praying church and a leader who called people to repentance.

Jeremiah Lanphier, a businessman in New York City, began a noonday prayer meeting for workers. His flyer for the event read:

”This meeting is intended to give merchants, mechanics, clerks, strangers, and businessmen generally an opportunity to stop and call upon God amid the perplexities incident to their respective avocations.”

Though the first meeting attracted only six people, it quickly grew. Within months, thousands across the city were gathering daily to pray. Businesses closed during the lunch hour to allow employees to seek God.

Within six months, 10,000 people were meeting daily in New York City alone. Over the next *two years*, it's estimated that nearly one million people came to faith as a result of this revival. The movement reached towns across the United States, leaving a lasting spiritual and cultural legacy. This demonstrated the power of prayer, repentance, and unity to transform a nation.

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## Joel's Call to Return

The principles that undergirded the Fulton Street Revival vividly echo the call to prayer and repentance found in Joel 2. The prophet Joel exhorts God's people with these words: "'Return to me with all your heart,' declares the Lord. 'Return to the Lord your God, for he is gracious and merciful, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love'" (Joel 2:12-13, ESV). This timeless declaration brings to mind God's revelation to Moses, in Exodus 34:6-7, when He displayed His glory. "The Lord, the Lord, the compassionate and gracious God, slow to anger, abounding in love and faithfulness" (Exodus 34:6-7, NIV).

Repentance, therefore, isn't merely an act of turning *away* from sin; it's an intentional *return* to the God who is good, merciful, and unchangingly faithful. It begins with a right understanding of God's character and leads to realignment with His purposes and heart.

This right knowledge of God is the foundation for spiritual renewal and must remain at the center of the church's message and mission.

The church's role isn't simply to oppose the broken systems of the world, but to actively equip believers with truth, righteousness, and the knowledge of God. Our focus must not be limited to what we stand against, but expanded to what we stand for—the transformative power of the Kingdom of God. Controversial and divisive issues such as race, sexuality, politics, and materialism underscore the urgent need for discipleship deeply rooted in Kingdom principles, beginning with the right knowledge of God.

If the church fails to lead families and communities in these truths, culture *will* fill the void. We're called to be a bold, clear voice—offering hope, unity, and a biblical perspective in the face of division and compromise.

Just as a herald declares a highway to be cleared, we must address these difficult subjects with courage and clarity. As the apostle Paul wrote, “We destroy arguments and every lofty opinion raised against the knowledge of God, and take every thought captive to obey Christ” (2 Cor. 10:5, ESV).

## Sexuality and Gender

A right understanding of God as our bridegroom profoundly shapes our response to issues of sexuality and gender. Revelation 19:7-8

portrays the church as the bride of Christ, adorned in purity and faithfulness. This imagery reminds us that sexual ethics transcend mere morality; they embody the spiritual reality of covenant relationship and intimacy with God.

In a culture that often promotes confusion and distortion regarding gender and sexuality, the church is called to lovingly and steadfastly *uphold* God's design as a testimony to His truth and goodness. By standing on this foundation, we reflect the profound beauty of His redemptive purposes and invite others into the fullness of life in Christ.

## Race and Unity

Acts 17:26 declares that God made every nation from *one man*, underscoring the equality and intrinsic worth of every human being. The right knowledge of God as Creator dismantles prejudice, bias, and division. It calls the church to model unity and reconciliation in a world fractured by racial and ethnic tensions.

Revelation 7:9 gives us a heavenly vision of every nation, tribe, people, and language worshiping together before the throne of God. This isn't just a future hope, but a present calling—to embody the Kingdom's inclusivity and love *now*. By embracing this vision, the church becomes a beacon of unity and healing in a divided world.

## Materialism

The knowledge of Jesus as righteous Judge compels us to guard our hearts against the seduction of materialism and the love of money. As Jesus warned in Matthew 6:19-20, “Do not store up for yourselves treasures on earth, where moths and vermin destroy, and where thieves break in and steal. But store up for yourselves treasures in heaven” (NIV).

Our stewardship of resources is *both* a reflection of our trust in God and a declaration of our allegiance to His Kingdom over worldly wealth. By aligning our priorities with God’s eternal purposes, we model a life that values heavenly treasures over temporal gains.

## Sanctity of Life

Recognizing God as the Author of life, the church is called to unwaveringly uphold the sanctity of life in *all* its forms. Psalm 139:13-16 celebrates God’s intimate knowledge of each person even before birth. “For you created my inmost being; you knit me together in my mother’s womb” (NIV).

The church’s mission includes advocating for the voiceless and offering compassion and hope to those facing difficult choices. By standing for life, we reflect the heart of a Creator who treasures every soul and redeems every life through His boundless grace.

## Summary

In all these areas—sexuality and gender, race and unity, materialism, and the sanctity of life—the right knowledge of God isn't only our starting point, but also our greatest tool for transformation. As the church, we're called to courageously proclaim and embody these truths, leading others into the fullness of life found in Christ alone.

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## John Wesley: Taking the Gospel to the People

John Wesley exemplified how the right knowledge of God fuels cultural impact. In the 18th century, when the Church of England rejected his message of repentance, Wesley took the gospel to the fields, preaching to coal miners and laborers who were excluded from traditional church services.

His commitment to reaching people where they *were* ignited one of the most significant revivals in history. Wesley's emphasis on holiness, discipleship, and societal transformation birthed the Methodist movement, a powerful example of how living out Kingdom values can transform culture.

By the time of Wesley's death in 1791, the Methodist movement had grown to over 71,000 members in England and 43,000 in America.



He preached over 40,000 sermons and traveled an estimated 250,000 miles on horseback to bring the gospel to people who had often been overlooked by religious institutions. Wesley's impact extended beyond spiritual revival; his advocacy for education, prison reform, and the abolition of slavery helped shape the social conscience of the British Isles in the 18th century.

One anecdote illustrating Wesley's determination occurred in 1742, when he was denied the opportunity to preach in his hometown church. Undeterred, he famously stood atop his father's tombstone in the churchyard and delivered a sermon to the gathered crowd. This act symbolized his unrelenting commitment to sharing the gospel wherever people could be found.

Wesley summarized his mission in the now-famous quote—"I look upon all the world as my parish." This reflects his belief that the gospel should reach beyond the walls of the church, engaging people in their everyday lives.

In addition, he also said, "Give me one hundred preachers who fear nothing but sin and desire nothing but God, and I care not whether they be clergymen or laymen; they alone will shake the gates of Hell and set up the kingdom of Heaven upon Earth." These words encapsulate his conviction that the church's mission is to go to where the people are, to preach the Word, and to transform lives through the power of the gospel.

## Being Salt and Light

In Matthew 5:13-16 (NIV), the Sermon on the Mount, Jesus describes the role of His followers as salt and light.

“You are the salt of the earth. But if the salt loses its saltiness, how can it be made salty again? It is no longer good for anything, except to be thrown out and trampled underfoot. You are the light of the world. A town built on a hill cannot be hidden. Neither do people light a lamp and put it under a bowl. Instead, they put it on its stand, and it gives light to everyone in the house. In the same way, let your light shine before others, that they may see your good deeds and glorify your Father in heaven.”

As salt, we’re called to preserve righteousness and prevent the moral decay of our culture. This preservation is only possible if we remain “salty”—maintaining the purity, integrity, and distinctiveness of our faith. When we compromise or dilute the truth, we lose our effectiveness as Kingdom influencers, becoming indistinguishable from the world we are called to transform.

As light, we are called to shine boldly and visibly, bringing hope, guidance, and clarity to an ever darkening world. A lamp isn’t meant to be hidden, but placed where its light can illuminate the entire room. Similarly, our lives should radiate good deeds that reflect the

love and truth of Christ, drawing others to glorify God. In this way, we actively shape culture, pointing people to the God who redeems and restores.

## Conclusion

This dual call to be salt and light encapsulates the church's mission to engage and transform the world. Like the early church in Acts 2, which grew in favor with God and people through salvation, devotion, unity, and generosity, we are called to embody Kingdom principles in both word and action. Our work isn't merely oppositional—standing against the culture's broken systems—but redemptive, proclaiming the hope and healing of the gospel.

# Chapter 10

## Growth of the Church

### A Culmination of Themes

This chapter draws together the essential elements of the church's growth as outlined in Acts 2—salvation, devotion, the power of the Holy Spirit, unity, generosity, and cultural impact. These themes form the foundation for the body of Christ, demonstrating how individual transformation leads to collective impact and cultural influence. Together, they culminate in the seventh seed— growth.

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### Individual Salvation

The church's journey begins with Peter's call to repentance in Acts 2:38. "Repent and be baptized, every one of you, in the name of Jesus Christ for the forgiveness of your sins. And you will receive the gift of the Holy Spirit" (NIV). This moment of turning from sin and receiving new life is the foundation for everything that follows. Salvation isn't merely an individual experience, but the doorway

into a Spirit-filled community, marking the start of a journey of transformation and purpose.

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## Devotion of the Community

Acts 2:42 outlines the communal practices of the early church. “They devoted themselves to the apostles’ teaching and to fellowship, to the breaking of bread and to prayer” (NIV). These rhythms of devotion deepened their connection to God and one another, creating a vibrant community that served as a powerful witness to the world. This model of shared life, centered on God’s Word, worship, and prayer, remains a timeless blueprint for building a thriving church.

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## The Power of the Holy Spirit

Acts 2:43 reminds us that the Spirit’s presence was awe-inspiring. “Everyone was filled with awe at the many wonders and signs performed by the apostles” (NIV). The Holy Spirit not only empowered individuals to preach and perform miracles, but also equipped the church as a whole for its mission.

Jesus' promise in Acts 1:8—"You will receive power when the Holy Spirit comes on you"—found its fulfillment at Pentecost and continues to resonate in Spirit-filled believers, enabling the church to grow in depth and reach.

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## Unity and Generosity

Acts 2:44-45 highlights the radical selflessness of the early believers. "All the believers were together and had everything in common. They sold property and possessions to give to anyone who had need" (NIV). Their unity and generosity stood in stark contrast to the individualism of their society, demonstrating the gospel's transformative power in tangible ways. This spirit of mutual care and sacrificial giving drew others to faith and remains a vital witness to the love of Christ.

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## Cultural Impact

The early church's unity, generosity, and Spirit-filled witness inevitably led to cultural impact. Acts 2:47 notes that the believers enjoyed "the favor of all the people," reflecting how their way of life stood out in their broader society. History shows that when the church actively engages the culture with the values of God's

Kingdom—justice, mercy, and love—it transforms not only individual lives but entire communities. Therefore, cultural impact becomes a key to sustainable growth.

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## Growth as the Seventh Seed

Growth is the natural culmination of these interconnected seeds. Acts 2:46-47 summarizes this cycle. “Every day they continued to meet together in the temple courts. They broke bread in their homes and ate together with glad and sincere hearts, praising God and enjoying the favor of all the people. And the Lord added to their number daily those who were being saved” (NIV).

Healthy things grow. Like a well-tended orchard, the church multiplies when rooted in devotion, empowered by the Spirit, and aligned with God’s purposes. This growth is *both* spiritual and numerical, extending the church’s reach to new generations and communities.

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## Reflections from History

### The Early Church

The growth of the early church was rooted in its counter-cultural witness during times of persecution. Christians' sacrificial love for one another and their care for the marginalized became a beacon of hope in the darkness of the Roman Empire. Tertullian's *Apologeticus* (AD 197) captures this vividly. "*See how they love one another.*"

This love wasn't just theoretical, but tangible. Christians rescued abandoned children, cared for the sick during plagues, and shared resources with the poor. Their actions stood in stark contrast to the self-serving and hostile nature of Roman society, showcasing a divine power greater than the empire itself. This radical witness drew many to faith despite the risks of persecution, planting seeds that would bear fruit for generations.

## The Methodist Movement

John Wesley's leadership in the Methodist revival transformed 18th-century England by addressing both personal holiness and societal reform. Wesley's conviction that "The gospel of Christ knows of no religion but social; no holiness but social holiness" led to the formation of Methodist societies where believers gathered in small groups for confession, prayer, and mutual accountability.

These societies were deeply rooted in the Acts 2 model, fostering a healthy spiritual life while engaging with the cultural challenges of their time. Methodists tackled issues like poverty, alcoholism, and



slavery, becoming agents of transformation in their communities. The movement's emphasis on both devotion and cultural impact led to a revival that not only renewed the church but also reshaped society.

## The Charismatic Renewal

The Azusa Street Revival (1906-1909), led by William J. Seymour, exemplifies the unifying and empowering work of the Holy Spirit. Seymour taught that the baptism of the Holy Spirit was available to all, breaking down racial, gender, and social barriers. The revival attracted people from around the world, sparking a global movement characterized by miraculous healings, prophetic words, and vibrant worship.

Building on this legacy, John Wimber of the Vineyard Movement emphasized equipping ordinary believers for ministry. His conviction that "everybody gets to play" democratized spiritual gifts, fueling a movement that grew to over 2,400 congregations in 95 countries. Both Azusa Street and the Vineyard demonstrated how Spirit-empowered communities could grow exponentially while breaking cultural and societal barriers.

## The Underground Church in China

The underground church in China reveals how persecution often fuels growth. Despite intense opposition, believers in China have devoted themselves to prayer, Scripture, and evangelism, often at tremendous personal risk. Brother Yun, in *The Heavenly Man* (Yun 56), recounts “The more we were persecuted, the more we grew.”

Miraculous stories of healings, visions, and bold evangelism have strengthened this movement, inspiring courage and faith among believers. Today, the underground church in China is estimated to include over 60 million believers, demonstrating how cultural impact and growth are intertwined even in the face of adversity.

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## Conclusion

The history of the church is ultimately that of God’s faithfulness and His people’s response. Furthermore, it’s a narrative of seeds sown in salvation, devotion, the Spirit’s power, unity, generosity, and cultural impact—all culminating in growth that glorifies God and transforms lives. Yet, as we celebrate this growth, we need to be mindful of the dangers that arise when the church’s focus shifts from God’s mission to human ambition.

One significant pitfall is hubris—an overconfidence in numbers, influence, or perceived success that neglects the foundational practices of Scripture and the lessons of history. Growth that prioritizes popularity over spiritual depth risks losing sight of the church's true purpose.

For example, Jesus Himself provides a clear example of how to navigate this tension. In John 6:1-15, He compassionately fed the multitude, demonstrating His provision. However, when the crowd sought to make Him king by force, He withdrew, rejecting their misplaced ambitions (John 6:15). Later, His teaching on being the Bread of Life (John 6:25-66) challenged their superficial motives, leading many to turn away.

Jesus was unafraid to winnow the crowd with truth, prioritizing spiritual depth over shallow popularity. This principle is critical for the church today. True growth mustn't come at the expense of preaching messages that challenge and refine believers.

For example, Paul reminds us of this in 1 Corinthians 3:2. "I gave you milk, not solid food, for you were not yet ready for it" (NIV). A thriving church must meet people where they are with practical teaching that addresses immediate needs such as building healthy families and equipping individuals for their callings. However, the church must also nurture believers toward maturity by offering the

‘meatier’ truths that deepen faith and align hearts with God’s purposes.

Healthy growth, like that of a flourishing orchard, isn’t forced but cultivated. The church grows when it’s rooted in Scripture, empowered by the Spirit, and aligned with God’s mission. It multiplies through the faithful planting of seeds—disciples raising disciples, communities impacting culture, and movements extending across generations. Yet, this growth must always remain focused on glorifying God, not on achieving human recognition or influence.

Ultimately, the goal of church growth isn’t to amass numbers or build earthly success, but to raise up disciples whose lives reflect God’s Kingdom. A healthy church engages culture with compassion and conviction, offering both the truth that transforms and the love that heals. Spiritual health and faithful service need to remain central, with the understanding that our ultimate reward lies not in earthly results, but in eternity with Christ.

By following Jesus’ example, grounding our practices in Scripture, and remaining dependent on the Spirit, we can avoid the pitfalls of hubris and ensure that the church’s growth glorifies God and fulfills His mission. The seeds planted in Acts 2 continue to bear fruit today, reminding us that healthy things grow and that growth, when

rooted in God's design, transforms both lives and cultures for His glory.

# Chapter 11

## The Context for the Seven Seeds to Flourish in Revival

The flourishing of the seven seeds—salvation, devotion, power, unity, generosity, cultural impact, and growth—is ultimately dependent on extraordinary devotion among God’s people, as they gather together to seek Him. Such dedication creates a dwelling place for God in the Spirit, positioning the church as a revival center in its city.

This chapter examines the biblical, historical, and practical frameworks of extraordinary devotion and the transformative power for revival it unleashes when the body of Christ is united and gathered.

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## Revival in Acts 19: A Case Study of Extraordinary Devotion

Imagine walking through the streets of Ephesus, one of the great cities of the ancient world. The towering Temple of Artemis dominates the skyline, its gleaming columns standing as a monument to pagan worship and a source of civic pride. Merchants crowd the marketplace, selling silver idols of Artemis, while priests perform rituals to honor the goddess. The air is thick with the sounds of commerce, the chants of worshipers, and the hum of philosophical debates in the agora.

Yet beneath the surface, something extraordinary is happening. Whispers ripple through the city of a man named Paul and his followers, whose teachings are spreading like wildfire. Crowds gather daily at the lecture hall of Tyrannus, where Paul speaks with a passion and authority that captivates his listeners. His message isn't about another god to add to the pantheon, but about Jesus, the resurrected King, who demands exclusive allegiance and offers a new way of life.

Strange and wondrous events accompany his ministry. Stories circulate of handkerchiefs and aprons touched by Paul being used to heal the sick and cast out evil spirits. People flock to hear him, some

are skeptical while others are desperate for the hope and power he proclaims.

Meanwhile, in homes and public squares, believers are confessing their sins and renouncing their old ways. Magicians burn their scrolls of sorcery in massive public bonfires, the flames lighting up the night sky. The smell of smoke mixes with the murmurs of astonished onlookers as fortunes worth 50,000 silver pieces go up in flames—a costly but joyous act of repentance.

The revival is shaking the foundations of Ephesus. The sale of idols declines sharply, provoking outrage among silversmiths who depend on the trade. In the theater, capable of holding thousands, the city erupts into chaos as angry mobs chant, “Great is Artemis of the Ephesians!” for hours, desperate to defend their goddess.

However, even in the face of this resistance, the movement grows. Lives are being transformed, families restored, and a city once defined by darkness is now witnessing the light of Christ breaking through.

At the heart of this revival is the extraordinary devotion of Paul, whose tireless ministry laid the groundwork for the flourishing of the seven seeds—salvation, devotion, power, unity, generosity, cultural impact, and growth. The following points illustrate how these seeds took root and bore fruit during this remarkable time.



## Salvation

Paul's ministry began by addressing the spiritual foundations. He led the disciples of John the Baptist to faith in Jesus and baptized them in His name (Acts 19:4-5). This act of salvation was the essential first step, preparing hearts to receive the fullness of the Holy Spirit and initiating them into a new life of faith.

## Devotion

The believers demonstrated extraordinary devotion by meeting daily in the hall of Tyrannus to learn from Paul (Acts 19:9-10). This commitment to consistent teaching and fellowship cultivated spiritual maturity, equipping them to stand firm in their faith amidst opposition.

## Power

God worked 'unusual miracles' through Paul, with even handkerchiefs and aprons bringing healing and deliverance (Acts 19:11-12). These displays of supernatural power authenticated the gospel message, drawing crowds and affirming that the God of Israel had authority over every spiritual and physical realm.

## Unity

The believers in Ephesus displayed remarkable unity when they brought their books of sorcery to be burned in a collective act of repentance (Acts 19:18-19). This public renunciation of their past lives bonded them together as a new community of faith and demonstrated their shared allegiance to Christ.

## Generosity

Paul modeled generosity by refusing to covet wealth or material possessions, inspiring others to follow his example (Acts 20:33-35). The believers also displayed a freedom from materialism by burning their valuable scrolls, placing their devotion to God above their possessions.

## Cultural Impact

The revival's effects rippled outward, disrupting the social and economic structures of Ephesus. The message of Christ not only changed individual lives, but also challenged the city's cultural norms and power dynamics (Acts 19:23-27). As the Word of the Lord grew mightily and prevailed (Acts 19:20), idolatry and the trade tied to it were severely weakened.

## Growth

Through Paul's ministry, the gospel spread throughout the region, reaching both Jews and Greeks. Acts 19:10 records that *all* of Asia Minor heard the Word of the Lord, illustrating how the seeds of revival planted in Ephesus multiplied into widespread spiritual and numerical growth.

Paul's later reflections with the Ephesian elders (Acts 20:17-38) reiterated the enduring impact of this revival. His ministry was characterized by humility, perseverance, and an unwavering commitment to preach the gospel. He poured his life into building a church that would continue to thrive even after his departure.

Paul's vision for the church as a "dwelling place for God in the Spirit" (Eph. 2:22, NIV) emphasizes the importance of unity and devotion. The body of Christ isn't merely a collection of individuals but a holy temple, built together to host the presence of God. This is actually what he wrote to the Ephesian church in his letter to them! This vision echoes the cry of David in Psalm 132, where the desire for a physical temple pointed to a deeper longing for God's manifest presence among His people.

The revival in Ephesus reveals what can happen when extraordinary devotion meets the power of the Holy Spirit. It transforms lives,

reshapes communities, and even challenges longstanding cultural, economic, and religious systems. When individuals and churches embrace this level of devotion, they create fertile ground for God's presence to dwell and His Kingdom to advance in power.

The flames of revival that burned in Ephesus continue to inspire believers today, reminding us that where there is devotion, there is transformation. However, in order to see this transformation, we need to heed the biblical mandate to gather together.

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## Gathering Together

In Scripture, the call to gather as a body is a central theme. The early church “gathered daily in the temple courts” (Acts 2:46, NIV), creating a rhythm of worship, teaching, and fellowship that allowed the seeds of revival to take root. Similarly, Hebrews 10:25 (NKJV) urges believers not to “forsake the assembling of ourselves together,” emphasizing mutual encouragement and accountability.

In the Old Testament, David's example reminds us that this kind of pursuit is costly. His zeal for God's people to gather in His presence to worship led him to endure public ridicule, fasting, and wearing sackcloth (Ps. 69:9-12).

Moreover, David financially committed to the temple, famously contributing 100,000 talents of gold for its construction. In today's terms, this equates to approximately \$228 billion, underscoring his extraordinary devotion. This immense sacrifice paved the way for God's presence to dwell among His people, as the temple would become the central place of worship for Israel and later the gathering place of the early church.

The words of the prophet Joel underscore further the power of corporate dedication. "Gather the people, sanctify the congregation, assemble the elders, gather the children..." (Joel 2:16, NKJV). This prophetic call to unity across generations mirrors the promise of 2 Chronicles 7:14 (NKJV). "If My people who are called by My name will humble themselves, and pray and seek My face, and turn from their wicked ways, then I will hear from heaven, and will forgive their sin and heal their land."

Acts 3:19 ties this together with the promise of "times of refreshing" coming from the presence of the Lord when we turn away from sin and toward God, revealing the extraordinary results of corporate prayer, repentance, and unity. We must know and believe these promises and appeal to God on their basis as a prescription for transformation in cities and regions that comes only as we gather together.

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## Extraordinary Devotion: A Call to Action

King David and Paul exemplify the extraordinary devotion required to bring about revival. Even as the king of Israel, David endured the humiliation of sackcloth, fasting, and being mocked by both the influential and the lowly in his pursuit of God's presence (Ps. 69:9-12, NIV).

In Psalm 132, his vow to forego rest and comfort until he established a dwelling place for God reveals his zealous heart. He declared, "Surely I will not go into the chamber of my house, or go up to the comfort of my bed; I will not give sleep to my eyes or slumber to my eyelids, until I find a place for the LORD" (Ps. 132:3-5, NIV). This unwavering commitment illustrates a refusal to settle for anything less than God's manifest presence dwelling among His people.

Paul's life similarly reflected this extraordinary devotion. His ministry in Ephesus, described in Acts 19 and 20, involved enduring physical suffering, emotional anguish, and relentless opposition. In Acts 20:19, 31 (NIV), he recounted his experience to the Ephesian elders. "Serving the Lord with all humility, with many tears and trials... I did not cease to warn everyone night and day with tears." Paul's zeal and perseverance created an environment where the seven seeds could flourish and bring transformative revival to the region.

During the Welsh Revival, Evan Roberts made comparable sacrifices. He resolved not to join his peers in leisure, famously saying, "I was tempted to turn back and join them on the tide." Instead, he attended prayer meetings faithfully.

For over a decade, he prayed and fasted for revival, often losing sleep as he labored in intercession. His extraordinary devotion created a spiritual atmosphere in which God's Spirit moved mightily, leading to over 100,000 conversions in less than a year.

Similarly, Duncan Campbell and the intercessors Peggy and Christine Smith were pivotal in the Hebrides Revival (1949-1952). Peggy and Christine Smith, aged 84 and 82, respectively, devoted themselves to prayer despite their physical limitations.

Peggy, blind, and Christine, crippled with arthritis, prayed fervently three nights a week, clinging to God's promise of "I will pour water upon him that is thirsty, and floods upon the dry ground" (Isa. 44:3, KJV). Their prayer opened the gates to God's outpouring in their parish.

Throughout history, movements of revival have been marked by such unusual dedication among God's people. Just as the California super bloom occurs when seeds that have lain dormant for years spring to life under the right conditions, revival flourishes when the body of Christ unites in extraordinary devotion leading to the

outpouring of the fresh rains of revival, touching the principles of God's word sown in people's hearts.

David's refusal to embrace "business as usual," Paul's perseverance through suffering to birth revival in Ephesus, Evan Roberts' long season of preparation, and the intercessory prayers of Peggy and Christine Smith all call us to embrace a similar resolve. These biblical and historical figures remind us that revival begins with uncommon faithfulness and a commitment to seek God at any cost.

Now, let's look at their examples more closely and see how the seeds of flourishing gave bloom in their communities in the context of revival.

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## The Welsh Revival: Evan Roberts' Extraordinary Devotion

The Welsh Revival of 1904-1905, led by Evan Roberts, illustrates the power of extraordinary devotion. Roberts' relentless prayers and uncompromising obedience to the Holy Spirit sparked a movement that saw over 100,000 conversions in less than a year. His commitment to confession, repentance, and intercession paved the way for an outpouring of God's Spirit.



The impact of the revival was profound and far-reaching. Churches were filled to capacity nightly, with services often lasting into the early hours of the morning. Prayer and worship replaced entertainment in many communities as the central focus of daily life. One observer wrote, "You can hardly go into a house in the village without hearing the people singing hymns" (Roberts, *The Welsh Revival*, 1905).

As people abandoned drinking and other vices, public houses and taverns experienced dramatic declines in business.. Courtrooms were often empty because crime rates fell significantly. One judge reportedly remarked that he had no cases to try, offering a pair of white gloves as a symbolic gesture to signify the purity of the times.

Eyewitness accounts capture the intensity of the revival. A newspaper journalist described the meetings as filled with "a sense of the supernatural so overwhelming that many are left in tears and others fall to their knees in prayer without any prompting" (*The Western Mail*, November 1904). In one gathering, attendees reported feeling waves of God's presence so tangible that it left the congregation in silent awe for hours.

Roberts' testimony echoes the principles seen in Ephesus. He emphasized:

- Confession of all known sin,

- Repentance and restitution,
- Obedience and surrender to the Holy Spirit, and
- Public confession of Christ.

Roberts famously described how his devotion kept him from distractions. "Many times, on seeing other boys with the boats on the tide, I was tempted to turn back and join them. But, no. I said to myself: 'Remember your resolve,' and on I went" (Roberts, *The Welsh Revival*, 1905).

Reflecting on his early years, Roberts recounted how he faithfully attended prayer meetings night after night, even as others his age sought leisure and entertainment in activities like sailing. His hunger for God was unrelenting, though the fulfillment of that hunger came only after years of perseverance.

For over a decade, Roberts disciplined himself in prayer and fasting, prioritizing spiritual preparation over personal comfort. He later wrote, "For ten or eleven years I prayed for revival, and I was moved by the Spirit to think about it constantly."

Finally, this resolve culminated in his mid-twenties when he experienced a powerful baptism of the Holy Spirit. This life-altering encounter marked the beginning of a sweeping revival, where waves of intercession and repentance engulfed entire communities.

Spontaneous prayer, confession, and worship became hallmarks of this divine movement, drawing thousands into a profound relationship with God (Roberts, *The Welsh Revival*, 1905).

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## When God's Manifest Power Invades a City

The Hebrides Revival (1949-1952) provides an extraordinary example of what happens when God's manifest power invades a city. Off the west coast of Scotland, a small group of islands witnessed a mighty move of God that began with the intercessory prayers of a few.

Two elderly sisters, Peggy and Christine Smith, played a pivotal role in opening the gate to this outpouring. These sisters, aged 84 and 82, respectively, were burdened by the spiritual condition of their parish. With Peggy blind and Christine almost entirely bent over by arthritis, they committed to praying three nights a week before their peat fire. They held to God's promise. "I will pour water upon him that is thirsty, and floods upon the dry ground" (Isaiah 44:3, KJV).

Their unusual devotion to prayer was the foundation of the revival. They challenged the local pastor to call the church to repentance and holiness, urging him to gather others to pray. Peggy and

Christine confidently told him, "God is coming, and He will bring revival to this parish."

One night, during a prayer meeting in a barn, a young man asked, "Are my hands clean, is my heart pure?" This question, drawn from Psalm 24, ignited a realization of God's holiness. Suddenly, those present were overwhelmed by the presence of God, moving them "from the sphere of the ordinary into the sphere of the extraordinary." Three people fell prostrate as they sensed they were now standing in the supernatural. That night marked the beginning of a revival that would shake the Isle of Lewis and its surrounding communities (Psalm 24: 3-4, NIV).

The impact of the Hebrides Revival was transformative. Entire villages were gripped by an awareness of God's presence, described as "God let loose through human personality." People would be found weeping by the roadside, overwhelmed by the conviction of sin.

In one account, a busload of people heading to a dance stopped when the Holy Spirit fell upon them. Instead they made their way to the church to seek God. Duncan Campbell, the evangelist drawn into the revival, described arriving at a parish to find hundreds gathered spontaneously, drawn not by advertisements, but by the irresistible presence of God.

Public life was transformed. Taverns closed, crime rates plummeted, and police found their workload significantly reduced. Instead of patrolling streets, officers joined prayer meetings. Witnesses noted that the very atmosphere seemed charged with the presence of God. A journalist observed, "The sense of the supernatural is so overwhelming that it leaves people in awe, silent or weeping" (Campbell, *The Price and Power of Revival*).

The Hebrides Revival demonstrates the extraordinary power of intercessory prayer, holiness, and hunger for God's presence. It stands as a testament to what happens when gates are lifted, and the King of Glory comes into a city (Psalm 24:7-10, NIV). Peggy and Christine Smith's faithfulness reminds us that revival often begins with those willing to persevere in extraordinary devotion to prayer, opening the way for God to move mightily.

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## A Promise of Flourishing

The promise of 2 Chronicles 7:14 reminds us that when God's people humble themselves, pray, and gather together, the result is divine healing and restoration. Acts 3:19 highlights the refreshing that comes from the presence of the Lord when repentance is embraced. Revival flows from the outpouring of the Spirit in a

united body, causing the seven seeds to flourish and bring transformation to individuals, communities, and cultures.

The unity of the body—anchored in salvation, empowered by the Spirit, enriched by teaching, strengthened through fellowship, marked by generosity, and driven by a shared purpose—creates the conditions for exponential growth and cultural impact. The flourishing of these seeds accelerates when the church embraces its identity as the dwelling place of God.

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## Conclusion: A Call to Extraordinary Devotion

However, revival is costly. As demonstrated by King David, Paul, Evan Roberts, sisters Peggy and Christine, and countless others whose names are only recorded in heaven, extraordinary devotion among a people creates a dwelling place for God in a city.

Moreover, David's refusal to rest until a dwelling place was established for God (Psalm 132) and Paul's unyielding dedication in Ephesus are enduring examples of the zeal required to cultivate revival. The revival in Acts 19 and the Welsh Revival remind us that unity, humility, and relentless pursuit of God's presence are *essential* for the flourishing of the seven seeds.

Like the California super bloom, where dormant seeds spring to life under the right conditions, revival in the church occurs when extraordinary devotion and unity create an atmosphere for God's Spirit to move.

Let's commit to this extraordinary devotion—to prayer, unity, and sacrificial love. As we humble ourselves, seek God's face, and dwell together in unity, we'll see the Spirit's outpouring and witness the flourishing of His kingdom in our midst. However, we can't be transformed if we fail to gather.

# Epilogue

## The Harvest Begins

As we come to the close of this journey through the Seven Seeds, I encourage you to pause and consider what God has planted in your heart. Each seed—salvation, devotion, power, unity, generosity, cultural impact, and growth—carries the potential to bear fruit, not just in your life but in the lives of those around you. But for a seed to flourish, it must be sown, nurtured, and cultivated in faith.

Jesus said, “The kingdom of God is as if a man should scatter seed on the ground, and should sleep by night and rise by day, and the seed should sprout and grow, he himself does not know how” (Mark 4:26-27, NKJV). The mystery of growth belongs to God, yet He calls us to be faithful sowers. His Word assures us, “So shall My word be that goes forth from My mouth; it shall not return to Me void, but it shall accomplish what I please, and it shall prosper in the thing for which I sent it” (Isaiah 55:11, NKJV).

As you step forward from this book, may you trust in God’s promise that every seed sown in faith will bear fruit in its season. Whether you are in a time of planting, watering, or harvesting, hold fast to



His word: “Let us not grow weary while doing good, for in due season we shall reap if we do not lose heart” (Galatians 6:9, NKJV). Now, let us seal this journey with a prayer of blessing.

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## Concluding Prayer of Blessing

Heavenly Father,

We come before You with gratitude for the timeless truths revealed in Your Word and the seeds sown through this book. You are the Lord of the harvest, and we trust that every seed planted will yield fruit in due time.

We pray a blessing over every reader, asking that the seeds of salvation, devotion, power, unity, generosity, cultural impact, and growth take deep root in their hearts. As Your Word declares, “Those who sow in tears shall reap with shouts of joy” (Psalm 126:5, ESV), may every seed planted in faith bring forth a harvest of righteousness and joy in the Holy Spirit.

Let the seed of salvation grow, fulfilling Your promise that “everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved” (Romans 10:13, ESV). For those seeking deeper devotion, may they echo the early church’s commitment to “the apostles’ teaching and the fellowship,

to the breaking of bread and the prayers” (Acts 2:42, ESV), drawing near to You in steadfast love.

For the seed of power, we ask for an outpouring of Your Spirit, as promised in Acts 1:8 (ESV): “You will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you, and you will be my witnesses.” Let signs and wonders follow those who believe, bringing glory to Your name.

We pray for unity, that Your Church may be one, just as You and the Son are one, as Jesus prayed in John 17:21 (ESV): “May they also be in us, so that the world may believe that you have sent me.” May this unity reflect Your love and draw others into Your family.

For the seed of generosity, remind us of Your words: “It is more blessed to give than to receive” (Acts 20:35, ESV). Let us overflow with generosity, meeting the needs of others and sowing into Your Kingdom.

We ask for cultural impact, that Your Word would grow mightily and prevail in every corner of society, just as it did in Ephesus: “So the word of the Lord continued to increase and prevail mightily” (Acts 19:20, ESV). Let Your Church be salt and light in a world longing for redemption.

Finally, Lord, we pray for the seed of growth, trusting in Your promise that “Whoever abides in me and I in him, he it is that bears

much fruit” (John 15:5, ESV). Let Your Kingdom come, and Your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven (Matthew 6:10, ESV).

Father, bless every reader with a renewed sense of purpose and a deepening relationship with You. May their lives bear fruit that multiplies, bringing Your Kingdom to their families, communities, and nations. Let the seeds sown through this book produce a legacy of transformation for generations to come.

We pray this in the mighty name of Jesus, the Lord of the harvest and the King of glory.

Amen.